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SELECTED WORKS



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Translated by

EDITH GROSSMAN

Edited by

ANNA MORE

UNIVERSITY OF BRASÍLIA



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A Letter from Sor Filotea to Sor Juana Inés de la Cruz *and* Response of the Poet to the Very Eminent Sor Filotea de la Cruz

Even as a cloistered nun, Sor Juana received gifts of books, continued to write, maintained a robust epistolary correspondence, and circulated her manuscripts. She also met with visitors in the *locutorio*, a small receiving room that permitted nuns to converse from behind an iron grille while remaining cloistered. Sor Juana's years in the viceregal court had connected her to the highest spheres of New Spanish society and, according to Father Calleja's posthumous biography, while in the convent she received visits from the political and intellectual elite of Mexico City.¹

During one of these visits Sor Juana expounded a critique of the Maundy Thursday Sermon preached in 1650 in the Royal Chapel of the Jesuit College in Lisbon by the famous Portuguese Jesuit António Vieira (1608–1697). Vieira's sermon took the story of Christ's washing of his disciples' feet at the Last Supper as a pretext for a reflection on which of Christ's qualities (*finezas*) was the greatest, considering first the opinions of three Church Doctors (Saint Augustine, Saint Ambrose, and Saint John Chrysostom). Sor Juana appears to have read Vieira's Maundy Thursday sermon in the 1678 Spanish translation, which Vieira had dedicated to the Jesuit Francisco de Aguiar y Seijas, the archbishop of New Spain. Because of the personal connection between the two Jesuits, it is probable that this edition circulated widely among the Mexican elite.

While Sor Juana's critique of Vieira's sermon is not often read now, it was considered impressive because of its tight scholastic logic, which included a consideration of the three doctors in Vieira's sermon and a pronouncement of her own conclusion on the matter of Christ's greatest quality. After Sor Juana first delivered her critique orally in the *locutorio* of the convent, a now unknown person asked for a version in writing. Apparently Sor Juana complied, as shortly afterward it was published in Puebla, the second largest city in colonial Mexico. The

1. See Calleja on p. 191.

printed version was titled *Carta Athenagórica* (Athenagoric letter),² although a separately published version in the 1692 *Second Volume* of Sor Juana's works titled it "Crisis de un sermón" (Critique of a sermon) and this may be the title Sor Juana herself preferred. The Puebla publication also contained a short prologue signed by another nun, Sor Filotea de la Cruz (see p. 86), praising Sor Juana's talents but reprimanding her for dedicating so much time to studying and writing on secular rather than sacred subjects.

Sor Filotea, or "Lover of God," was not a nun but a pseudonym that permitted the true author of the prologue, the bishop of Puebla, Manuel Fernández de Santa Cruz (1637–1699), to communicate his reprimand as sisterly advice from one nun to another. Sor Juana knew exactly who had written the prologue but followed the ruse. After a period of silence, she penned a lengthy epistle, now known as "Response of the Poet to the Very Eminent Sor Filotea de la Cruz," following the title given when it was printed in 1700 in the posthumous volume of her works. In an exquisite rhetorical architecture, Sor Juana employs a variety of strategies to dismantle the criticism she had received from the bishop, honing arguments that she had already employed ten years earlier in response to similar criticism from her then confessor, the influential Jesuit Antonio Núñez de Miranda (see p. 144). The "Response," however, is a tighter and lengthier argument that employs strategies from forensic oratory to unravel step by step the bishop's accusation and to build an alternative case.

The center of Sor Juana's letter is a defense against the bishop's main charge that "God does not want letters that give rise to presumption in woman." Sor Juana counters this charge that writing on secular subjects leads to vanity and disobedience with four main arguments: (1) "except for a trifle they call *The Dream*," she had never written anything according to her own will but rather to satisfy the requests of others; (2) from the time she was born she has shown a natural inclination toward study and writing and that this inclination was a "divine impulse" that human mandates, including her own, had not been able to stifle; (3) the Church itself has numerous examples of learned women, all of whom are celebrated rather than maligned; and (4) as the intellect of men and women has a common origin in the divine, they should be treated equally.

The rhetorical labyrinth in which Sor Juana couched this argument was as important as its essence.³ The irony, even sarcasm, of the letter is especially evident in the opening superlatives and exaggerated rhetoric of humility, the most acceptable stance for religious women in her period.⁴ Irony also marks her expression of gratitude toward the bishop

2. Although the title has often been translated "Letter Worthy of Athena," it more likely refers to Athenagoras, the author of an *Apologia* (177 C.E.) defending Christianity against pagan accusations.

3. Rosa Perelmutter Pérez has shown that the "Response" follows the rhetorical structure of forensic argument, including an exordium, narration, proof, and conclusion as well as other essential strategies suggested by Cicero and Quintillian, such as the opening *captatio benevolentiae* that flatters the recipient. Rosa Perelmutter Pérez, "La estructura retórica de la Respuesta a Sor Filotea," *Hispanic Review* 51, 2 (1983): 152–53.

4. See the selection from Saint Teresa's *The Life*, on p. 174.

for publishing her letter, even as he warned her against the vanity that such recognition could cause. While not strictly an autobiography, Sor Juana's recounting of her prodigious abilities as a girl and her experience in the convent community, including when a mother superior prohibited her from studying, are some of the few sources for information on her life. It is often forgotten that these occur within a greater argument that she is naturally "inclined" to study and write. In essence, Sor Juana trumps the Church hierarchy by claiming that her natural abilities are God-given. Yet her short-circuiting of the Church as an institution holds none of the rhetoric of mysticism, nor does it depend on the rhetoric of holy ignorance adopted by the models she cites in her list of learned women: Saint Teresa and Sor María de Ágreda. Sor Juana does not gain knowledge through mystical abnegation but through natural impulse and laborious study.

Sor Juana's arguments that girls be allowed to study or her exegesis of the main biblical source for suppressing women's learning, the Pauline dictum *mulieres in ecclesiis taceant* (let women in the church be silent), are more directly reasoned. Her conclusions, that if men are problematic teachers, the solution is to train more women to teach, or that Paul intended his dictum to address women's public speech rather than private study, are ingeniously argued. Yet Sor Juana also constantly authorizes her conclusions by a range of patristic sources, by biblical examples, and even by the little-known Mexican theologian Dr. Arce.⁵ At other times, her biting wit cuts the counterargument to the quick, as in when she writes that her arguments should be heeded also by men, "who for the simple fact of being men think they are wise." Such statements go so far as to imply that by attacking her, the Church hierarchy, including even the bishop himself, is allied with ignorance, vanity, or simply nonsensical reasoning.

Yet perhaps the most important argument in the "Response" rests on the idea that the intellect has no gender, expressed near the end of the letter when she notes that her intellect and Vieira's share a common origin, and should have the same freedom to critique authorities. This does not mean that Sor Juana adopts an implicitly male point of view. In fact, she continually evokes a gendered perspective, citing girls' love of long hair or sweets or arguing in favor of studying in the kitchen, and concluding that "if Aristotle had cooked, he would have written a great deal more." Implicitly, by unleashing her abilities in the "Response" she both gives lie to the notion that women are incapable intellects and supports her statement that to speak or not to speak, to reason or not to reason is not a matter of her free will but a necessity. Sor Juana constantly asserts that she is impelled by an interior and natural truth.

Critics have debated to what extent the "Response" is the culmination of a lifelong battle between Sor Juana and the Church hierarchy. Often at stake is the sincerity of her statements, a sincerity almost impossible to judge given the rhetorical cloaking of her arguments. Third party writings, such as the Calleja biography that prefaced her final, posthumous volume of works, imply that Sor Juana was indeed

5. See p. 112.

attacked, especially after the publication of the "Athenagoric Letter." But others were drawn to her "scholastic reasoning," and the battle, carried out in manuscripts or in encomiastic poems, appears to have been evenly balanced between supporters and attackers.⁶ Because only two years later she renounced her secular studies, sold her books, and retook her vows, it remains unclear exactly what place the "Response" holds in the interior and exterior battles surrounding Sor Juana's lifelong impulse to study and write.

This edition retains section breaks added by Edith Grossman in her translation. They did not appear in the original letter.

A Letter from Sor Filotea to Sor Juana Inés de la Cruz[†]

Señora:

I have seen the letter from Your Grace in which you challenge the qualities of Christ which Reverend Father Antonio de Vieira described in his Maundy Thursday Sermon¹ with so much subtlety that it has seemed to the most erudite men that, like another Eagle of the Apocalypse, this singular talent had soared beyond itself, following in the footsteps of the most Eminent César Meneses,² one of the finest minds in Portugal; but in my judgment, whoever reads Your Grace's apologia³ cannot deny that your pen was cut finer than either of theirs, and they can take pride in finding themselves challenged by a woman who is the glory of her sex.

I, at least, have admired the acuteness of your concepts, the sagacity of your proofs, and the forceful clarity, inseparable companion of learning, with which you argue the matter, for the first word the Deity said was *light*,⁴ because without clarity there is no word for learning. Even Christ, when He spoke of the highest mysteries behind the veil of parables, was not admired

6. Several of these manuscripts, discovered in Peru by José Antonio Rodríguez Garrido, give key details about the chronology of Sor Juana's critique and the extent of the scandal that followed it. José Antonio Rodríguez Garrido, *La Carta atenagórica de Sor Juana: textos inéditos de una polémica* (Mexico: UNAM, 2004).

† The actual author was the bishop of Puebla, don Manuel Fernández de Santa Cruz. The pseudonym "Filotea" (literally, "lover of God") may reflect its use by the influential archbishop of Mexico Juan de Palafox y Mendoza in his *Peregrinación de Filotea al Santo templo y monte de la Cruz* (The pilgrimage of Filotea to the holy temple and Mount of the Cross, 1659) [revised by Editor].

1. Several sermons by the Portuguese Jesuit António Vieira (1608–1697) carry the title of Maundy Thursday, preached on the Thursday of Easter week. The one that Sor Juana critiqued was preached in 1650 in the Royal Chapel of the Jesuit College in Lisbon. The mass recalls Christ's washing of his disciples' feet at the Last Supper (John 13:3–20) [Editor].

2. Sebastião César de Meneses (d. 1671) was an archbishop of Lisbon and author of theological works that inspired Vieira [Editor].

3. In rhetoric, a self-defense [Editor].

4. God's commandment "let there be light" (*fiat lux*) in Genesis 1:3 [Editor].

in the world; only when He spoke clearly was He acclaimed for knowing everything. This is one of the many benefits Your Grace owes to God, because clarity is not acquired through effort and industry: it is a gift that is infused⁵ with the soul.

I have had your letter printed so that Your Grace may be seen in better form and may recognize the treasures God has placed in your soul and, having more understanding, may be more grateful: for gratitude and understanding were always born at the same time. And if, as Your Grace says in your letter, whoever has received more from God has a greater obligation to repay, I fear Your Grace may be deeply in debt, for few creatures owe the Lord greater natural talents; therefore express your gratitude so that if until now you have used those talents well (which I believe of anyone who has entered your order), from now on you will use them better.

My judgment is not so austere a censor that it takes exception to your verses—for which Your Grace has been so celebrated—since Saint Teresa and Gregory of Nazianzus⁶ and other saints canonized this ability with their poems, but I should like you to imitate them in the choice of subjects as well as in technique.

I do not condone the vulgarity of those who reprove the practice of letters in women, for many applied themselves to this study, and not without the praise of Saint Jerome.⁷ True, Saint Paul says that women should not teach, but he does not direct women not to study in order to learn, because he wished only to avoid the danger of presumption in our sex, always so inclined to vanity.⁸ Divine Wisdom removed a letter from the name Sarai and added one to the name Abram, not because the man has to have more letters than the woman, as many believe, but because “i” added to the name Sara indicated pride and authority. My lady is translated as *Sarai*, and it was not proper for one who worked as a servant in the house of Abraham to be a lady.⁹

5. The verb *infundir*, a theological term for the process of receiving knowledge through divine grace. Mysticism was known as an “infused knowledge” (*ciencia infusa*) [Editor].

6. Saint Gregory of Nazianzus, also called Gregory Nanzianzen (540–604 C.E.), Doctor of the Church and archbishop of Constantinople. Saint Teresa, also called Teresa de Jesús and Teresa of Ávila (1515–1582), a prominent Spanish mystic and writer who was canonized in 1622 (see p. 174). Each wrote small bodies of verse [Editor].

7. A Doctor of the Church (347–410 C.E.) known for his erudition and founder of the Hieronymite order to which Sor Juana’s Convent of Saint Paula pertained [Editor].

8. The dictate is found in 1 Corinthians 14:34–35: “Let your women keep silence in the churches: for it is not permitted unto them to speak; but they are commanded to be under obedience as also saith the law. And if they will learn any thing, let them ask their husbands at home: for it is a shame for women to speak in the church.” It was one of the major fundaments for delineating women’s participation in the Church [Editor].

9. The reference is to the Old Testament story of Sarah, who gave her servant Hagar to her husband Abraham to bear them a child. In Genesis 17:15 God removes the letter “i” from Sarai, making her Sarah in Hebrew. Both mean “mistress” or “princess,” and thus underscored Sarah’s authority in the household. Santa Cruz appears to confuse Hagar, who was the servant, for Sarah, the mistress [Editor].

God does not want letters that give rise to presumption in woman, but the Apostle¹ does not censure letters unless they remove woman from a state of obedience. It is well known that study and learning have kept Your Grace in a subordinate state and helped you perfect the graces of obedience; for if other religious women sacrifice their will to obedience, Your Grace has ceded your understanding, which is the most arduous and pleasing offering that can be made in the name of a religious calling.

By giving this advice, it is not my intention that Your Grace alter your nature by renouncing books but improve it by reading the book of Jesus Christ from time to time. None of the Evangelists called the genealogy of Christ a book except Saint Matthew, because in his conversion he wished not to change his inclinations but to improve them, so that if once, as a tax collector,² he spent his time on books that dealt with contracts and interest, as an Apostle he devoted himself to improving his nature by exchanging the books of his perdition for the book of Jesus Christ. Your Grace has spent a good deal of time studying philosophers and poets; now is the proper moment for you to perfect your pursuits and improve the books you read.

Was there ever a nation more erudite than Egypt? The first letters in the world originated there, and their hieroglyphics were a cause for astonishment. Extolling the wisdom of Joseph, Holy Scripture calls him unmatched in his knowledge of Egyptian erudition.³ And yet the Holy Spirit states openly that the Egyptian nation is barbaric, for all their learning merely penetrated the movements of the stars and the heavens but could not rein in the disorder of their passions; all their knowledge was devoted to perfecting man in his political life but did not enlighten him on how to attain the life eternal. And knowledge that does not light the way to salvation is deemed foolishness by God, Who knows all things.

This was the opinion of Justus Lipsius⁴ (a wonder of erudition) when he was close to death and the final reckoning, a time when our understanding is most enlightened: as his friends consoled him, recalling the many erudite books he had written, he said, pointing to a crucifix: *Knowledge that does not come from the Crucified God is foolishness and mere vanity.*⁵

1. Saint Paul, according to the dictate mentioned in n. 8, p. 87 [Editor].

2. Or bookkeeper; see Matthew 9:9 [Editor].

3. Santa Cruz's references are vague. In Acts 7:10–22 Joseph is called wise, but "Egyptian wisdom" is attributed to Moses. Lawrance, n. 172. Neoplatonists were responsible for the common Renaissance idea that Egypt was the oldest source of human knowledge and that hieroglyphs were an Adamic script [Editor].

4. A prominent Flemish humanist (1547–1606) whose influential works espoused a Christian Neostoicism [Editor].

5. The source is unknown [Editor].

I do not condemn the reading of these authors for this reason, but I repeat to Your Grace what Gerson⁶ advised: Lend yourself to these studies, do not let them betray you or rob you. Human letters are slaves to divine letters and tend to make use of them, but should be condemned when they steal from Divine Wisdom its possession of human understanding and transform those destined for servitude into fine ladies. They are commendable when the reason for curiosity, which is a vice,⁷ becomes studiousness, which is a virtue.

The angels whipped Saint Jerome because he read Cicero,⁸ seduced rather than as a free man, as he preferred the delight of his eloquence to the solidity of Holy Scripture; yet it is to be commended that the Holy Doctor made use of the facts and profane erudition obtained from such authors.

The time Your Grace has spent on fields of knowledge that arouse curiosity is not negligible; now, like the great Boethius,⁹ turn your attention to fields that are more profitable, joining to the subtleties of natural knowledge the usefulness of moral philosophy.

It is a pity when so great an understanding becomes so immersed in base earthly matters that it does not wish to penetrate what occurs in Heaven; and since you humble yourself to the earth, sink no lower but consider what happens in Hell. And if on occasion you desire sweet and tender tidings, turn your understanding to Mount Calvary,¹ where, observing the loving kindness of the Redeemer and the ingratitude of the redeemed, you will find ample scope for pondering the abundance of infinite love and marshaling a defense, not without tears, against utmost ingratitude. Or, on other occasions, most usefully launch the magnificent galleon of Your Grace's intelligence onto the high seas of divine perfections. I have no doubt that you will have the same experience as Apelles,² who painted the portrait of Campaspe, and with each stroke of his brush on the canvas, the arrow of love left a wound in his heart, so that the painter was at once perfecting the portrait while his love for the original inflicted mortal wounds to his heart.

6. Jean Gerson (1363–1429), a Parisian theologian responsible for numerous spiritual treatises [Editor].

7. Curiosity was commonly held to be a vice, as it led to vain knowledge [Editor].

8. In his *Letter to Eustochium on Virginity*, *Epistula* 22.30. Saint Jerome recalls a dream in which he is whipped by angels for reading the pagan Cicero [Editor].

9. Anicius Manlius Severinus Boethius (ca. 480–524), a Roman philosopher who wrote *On the Consolation of Philosophy*, widely read in Christian Europe as a treatise on death and fortune, while awaiting execution. He was incorrectly presumed to be a Christian [Editor].

1. The site immediately outside of Jerusalem's walls where Christ, the "Redeemer" in Santa Cruz's statement, was said to have been crucified for the sake of humanity, the "redeemed" [Editor].

2. He painted a portrait of Campaspe, the mistress of Alexander the Great, and subsequently fell in love with her [Editor].

I am very certain that if Your Grace, with the keen rationality of your understanding, were to form and depict an idea of divine perfections (whatever the dark shadows of faith allow), at the same time you would find your soul illuminated by light and your will blazing with and sweetly wounded by love of God, so that Our Lord, who has so abundantly showered Your Grace's nature with positive benefits, will not find Himself obliged to grant only negative benefits to your spirit; for no matter how Your Grace's intelligence may call them kindnesses, I deem them punishments, because it is a benefit only when God prepares the human heart with His Grace so that we may respond with gratitude, making use of a recognized benefit so that Divine Generosity is not held back but makes those benefits even greater.

This is the wish for Your Grace of one who, ever since she kissed your hand many years ago,³ has lived enamored of your soul with a love that neither distance nor time has cooled; for spiritual love does not suffer periods of mutability, and love that is pure does not acknowledge mutability unless it leads to growth. May Our Lord hear my prayers and make Your Grace very holy and keep you well.

From the Convent of the Holy Trinity, in Puebla de los Ángeles, 25 November 1690.

I kiss Your Grace's hand and am your affectionate servant,
Filotea de la Cruz

Response of the Poet to the Very Eminent Sor Filotea de la Cruz[†]

Very eminent lady, my señora:

Neither my will nor scant health nor reasonable apprehension has delayed my response for so many days. Is it any surprise that my dull pen stumbled over two impossibilities at its first step? The first (and for me the more severe) is how to respond to your most learned, most prudent, most saintly, and most loving letter.¹ For if the Angelic Doctor of the Schools, Saint Thomas, when questioned regarding his silence in the presence of Albertus

3. This statement has been seen as proof that the bishop was not the one who requested the *Athenagoric Letter* in writing, as it would seem that he was not present when she first spoke her critique [Editor].

† Sor Juana responds to the "Letter from Sor Filotea" (p. 86). Sor Juana knew that the bishop of Puebla, Manuel Fernández de Santa Cruz, was the actual author of the letter but accepts the pretense of the pseudonym, addressing her own response to Sor Filotea and referring throughout to its recipient as "Señora" and a nun [Editor].

1. In the original, these superlatives are marked by the suffix *-ísimo* and are clearly ironic [Editor].

Magnus,² his teacher, replied that he was silent because he could find nothing to say worthy of Albertus, with how much more reason should I be silent, not, like the saint, out of humility, but because in reality, I know nothing worthy of you. The second impossibility is how to thank you for the favor, as unwarranted as it was unexpected, of having my rough scribbles printed; a good turn so immeasurable that it surpasses the most ambitious hope and most fantastic desire, which could find no place, even as a rational concept,³ in my thoughts; in short, it is of such magnitude that it not only cannot be reduced to the limits of words but exceeds the capacity of gratitude, as much for its dimensions as for how unforeseen it was, for as Quintilian said: *Hopes give rise to the lesser glory, benefits to the greater.*⁴ So much so that they silence the beneficiary.

When the happily barren, only to be made miraculously fruitful, mother of the Baptist saw so magnificent a visitor as the Mother of the Word in her house, her understanding became clouded and her speech failed, and so instead of thanks she burst into doubts and questions: *Et unde hoc mihi?* From whence comes such a thing to me?⁵ The same occurred to Saul when he found himself elected and anointed king of Israel: *Am I not a son of Jemini of the least tribe of Israel, and my kindred the last among all the families of the tribe of Benjamin? Wherefore then hast thou spoken this word to me?*⁶ And so say I: from whence, illustrious señora, from whence comes so great a favor to me? Am I by chance anything more than a poor nun, the most insignificant creature in the world and the least worthy of your attention? *Wherefore then speakest thou so to me? From whence comes such a thing to me?*

To the first impossibility I can respond only that I am unworthy of your eyes, and to the second I cannot respond with anything other than exclamations, not thanks, saying that I am

2. Albertus Magnus (ca. 1200–1280) was Saint Thomas's teacher at the University of Paris. "The Angelic Doctor": a common epithet for Saint Thomas Aquinas (ca. 1225–1274), author of the *Summa Theologica* and other works that adapted Aristotelian metaphysics to Christian theology and dogma. The Thomist corpus was considered the foundation for scholastic theology, or the "Schools" [Editor].

3. Sor Juana uses the Spanish translation of the scholastic term *ens rationis*, or an abstract object of understanding with no real presence outside of the mind [Editor].

4. Marcus Fabius Quintilianus (35–ca. 96 C.E.), a Roman rhetorician and author of the influential *Institutio oratoria* (ca. 95 C.E.) outlining the principles of rhetoric. Sor Juana's phrase, *minorem spei, maiorem benefacti gloriam pariunt*, misquotes his *Institutio oratoria* III 7.13: "*quo minores opes fuerunt maiorem bene factis gloriam parit*" (where wealth is less, [panegyric] gets more glory from good deeds). Throughout, Latin phrases in the text will be translated and italicized [Editor].

5. Luke 1:43. The phrase was uttered by Elizabeth, cousin of the Virgin Mary and mother of John the Baptist, a birth considered a miracle because of Elizabeth's advanced age. In an event known as the Visitation, her pregnancy was announced when the Virgin Mary visited her cousin and the child leapt in Elizabeth's womb [Editor].

6. 1 Samuel 9:21. The response of Saul to Samuel's prophecy that he will be the first king of Israel [revised by Editor].

not capable of offering you even the smallest portion of the gratitude I owe you. It is not false modesty, señora, but the candid truth of all my soul, that when the letter your eminence called *Athenagoric*⁷ reached me, I burst (although this does not come easily to me) into tears of confusion, because it seemed that your favor was nothing more than a reproach from God for how poorly I meet His expectations; while He corrects others with punishments, He wants to reduce me by means of benefits. A special favor, for which I know I am in His debt, as I am for other infinite benefits from His immense kindness, but also a special mode of shaming and confusing me: for it is a more exquisite method of punishment to have me, with my knowledge, serve as the judge who sentences and condemns my own ingratitude. When I ponder this, here in solitude, I often say: *Lord may You be blessed, for You not only did not wish any other creature to judge me, and did not give me that responsibility either, but kept it for Yourself and freed me from me and the sentence I would have given myself—which, compelled by my own knowledge, could not be less than condemnation—and reserved that for Your mercy, because You love me more that I can love myself.*

Señora, forgive the digression that the power of truth demanded of me, and if I must confess the whole truth, this is also a search for havens to escape the difficulty of responding, and I almost decided to leave everything in silence, but since this is negative, although it explains a great deal with the emphasis on not explaining, it is necessary to add a brief explanation so that what one wishes the silence to say is understood; if not, the silence will say nothing, because that is its proper occupation: saying nothing. The sacred chosen vessel was carried away to the third heaven, and having seen the arcane secrets of God, the text says: *He . . . heard secret words, which it is not granted to man to utter.*⁸ It does not say what he saw but says that he cannot say; and so it is necessary at least to say that those things that cannot be said cannot be said, so it is understood that being silent does not mean having nothing to say, but that the great deal there is to say cannot be said in words. Saint John says that if all the miracles performed by Our Redeemer were to be written down, the entire world could not hold the books;⁹

7. When the Bishop Manuel Fernández de Santa Cruz published Sor Juana's critique in 1690, he titled it *Athenagoric Letter*. While for many years it was assumed that "Athenagoric" referred to "Athena," rendering the translation "Letter Worthy of Athena," it likely refers to Athenagoras, the author of an *Apologia* (177 C.E.) defending Christianity against pagan accusations [revised by Editor].

8. 2 Corinthians 12:4. Sor Juana mistakenly attributes the vision to the "sacred chosen vessel" or Paul himself (Acts 9:15), when Paul's anecdote refers to another man [revised by Editor].

9. John 21:25.

and Vieira states that the Evangelist says more in just this passage than in everything else he wrote; the Lusitanian Phoenix, speaks very well (but when does he not speak well, even when he does not speak well?),¹ because here Saint John says everything he did not say and expressed what he did not express. And I, señora, will respond only that I do not know how to respond, will only give thanks, saying I am not capable of giving thanks to you, and will say, as a brief explanation of what I leave to silence, that only with the confidence of a favored woman and the benefits of an honored one can I dare speak to your excellency. If this is foolishness, forgive it, for it is a jewel of good fortune, and in it I will provide more material for your kindness, and you will give greater form to my gratitude.

Because he stammered, Moses did not think he was worthy to speak to the Pharaoh, and afterward, finding himself so favored by God fills him with so much courage that he not only speaks to God Himself but dares ask Him for impossibilities: *Shew me thy face*.² And I too, señora, no longer think impossible what I wrote at the beginning, in view of how you favor me; because the person who had the letter printed without my knowledge, who gave it a title and paid for it, who honored it so greatly (since it is entirely unworthy both for its own sake and the sake of its author), what will she not do, what will she not pardon, what will she cease doing, and what will she cease pardoning? And so, under the assumption that I speak with the safe-conduct of your favors and under the protection of your kindness, and your having, like another Ahasuerus, given me the tip of the golden scepter of your affection to kiss as a sign of granting me benevolent license to speak³ and propound in your illustrious presence, I say that I receive in my soul your most saintly admonition to turn my studies to sacred books, which although this comes in the guise of advice will have for me the substance of a precept, with the not insignificant consolation that even earlier it seems my obedience foresaw your pastoral suggestion, as well as your guidance, inferred from the subject and proofs of the same letter. I know very well that your most sage warning is not directed at it⁴ but at how much

1. António Vieira: "Lusitanian" is Portuguese, and a "phoenix" is a remarkable person. Sor Juana herself was called the "Mexican Phoenix." The citation is from his "Sermon of Our Lady of Peñafrancia" preached in 1652: "*Pergunto agora: Em que disse mais S. João: em estas duas ultimas regras ou em todo seu Evangelho?*" (I ask now: In which did Saint John say more: in these last two lines or in his entire gospel?) [Editor].

2. Found in the Song of Solomon 2:14. Lawrance notes that Sor Juana combines various biblical passages to come to this conclusion. Moses's stutter is mentioned in Exodus 4:10. In Exodus 33:18, Moses says "shew me thy glory." Lawrance, n. 14 [revised by Editor].

3. Esther 5:2. The Persian King Ahasuerus gave Esther permission to speak by holding out his golden scepter for her to touch [revised by Editor].

4. That is, the bishop's reprimand does not refer to the contents of the *Athenagoric Letter*, which are theological [Editor].

you have seen of my writings on human affairs; and so what I have said is only to satisfy you with regard to the lack of application you have inferred (and rightly so) from other writings of mine. And speaking more specifically I confess, with the candor that is owed you and with the truth and clarity that in me are always natural and customary, that my not having written a great deal about sacred matters has been due not to defiance or lack of application but to an abundance of the fear and reverence owed to those sacred letters, for whose comprehension I know myself highly incapable and for whose handling I am highly unworthy; resounding always in my ears, with no small horror, is the Lord's warning and prohibition to sinners like me: *Why dost thou declare my justices, and take my covenant in thy mouth?*⁵ My great father Saint Jerome confirms this question, and that even learned men are forbidden to read the Song of Solomon and even Genesis before the age of thirty (the latter because of its obscurity, the former so that imprudent youth will not use the sweetness of those nuptial songs as an excuse to alter their meaning to carnal love), by ordering that it be the last book studied, for the same reason: *At the end one may read, without danger, the Song of Songs; for if it is read at the beginning, when one does not understand the epithalamium to the spiritual marriage beneath the carnal words, one may suffer harm;*⁶ and Seneca says: *In the early years, faith is not bright.*⁷ Then how would I dare hold it in my unworthy hands, when it is in conflict with my sex, my age, and especially, my customs? And so I confess that often this fear has removed the pen from my hand and made subjects withdraw into the same understanding from which they wished to emerge; this difficulty was not encountered in profane subjects, for a heresy against art is punished not by the Holy Office⁸ but by the prudent with laughter and the critics with condemnation; and this, *just or unjust, there is no reason to fear it,*⁹ for one can still take Communion and hear Mass and therefore it concerns me very little or not at all; because according to the same opinion of those who cast aspersions, I have no obligation to know and no aptitude for being correct; therefore, if I err there is no blame and no discredit. There is no blame because I have no obligation; there is no discredit because I have no possibility of being

5. Psalm 50:16 [revised by Editor].

6. Saint Jerome, *To Laeta, Upon the Education of Her Daughter* (written ca. 403 C.E.).

7. The 1700 edition of the "Response" incorrectly attributes this to *De beneficiis* (On Kindness) by Lucius Annaeus Seneca (ca. 4 B.C.E.–65 C.E.). It is from *Octavia* 1.538, a play most likely incorrectly attributed to Seneca, and the wording differs slightly from Sor Juana's original. Lawrance, n. 18 [Editor].

8. The Spanish Inquisition.

9. A citation from the *Decretum*, a collection of rules and regulations of the Church, compiled in 1140 by the Benedictine monk Gratian, C.11.3.1. Lawrance, n. 20 [Editor].

correct, and *no one is obliged to undertake impossible things*.¹ And, truly, I have never written except reluctantly, when I was forced to, and only to please others; not only with no gratification but with positive repugnance, for I have never judged myself to possess the abundance of letters and intelligence demanded by the obligation of one who writes; and so my usual reply to those who urge me to write, especially if the subject is sacred: "What understanding, what studies, what materials, what rudimentary knowledge do I possess for this other than some superficial nonsense? Leave this for someone who understands it, for I wish no quarrel with the Holy Office, for I am ignorant and terrified of stating an offensive proposition or twisting the genuine significance of some passage. I do not study to write, much less to teach (which would be excessive pride in me), but only to see whether by studying I will be less ignorant." This is how I respond and how I feel.

Writing has never been by my own volition but at the behest of others; for I could truthfully say to them: *Ye have compelled me*.² A truth I will not deny (one, because it is widely known, and two, because even if used against me, God has favored me with a great love of the truth) is that ever since the first light of reason struck me, my inclination toward letters has been so strong and powerful that neither the reprimands of others—I have had many—nor my own reflections—I have engaged in more than a few—have sufficed to make me abandon this natural impulse that God placed in me: His Majesty knows why and to what end; and He knows I have asked Him to dim the light of my understanding, leaving only enough for me to obey His Law, for anything else is too much in a woman, according to some; there are even those who say it does harm. Almighty God knows too that when I did not obtain this, I attempted to bury my understanding along with my name and sacrifice it to the One who gave it to me; for no other reason did I enter a convent, although the spiritual exercises and companionship of a community were incompatible with the freedom and quiet my studious intentions demanded; the Lord knows, as does the only one in the world who had to know, that once in the community I attempted to hide my name but was not permitted to, for it was said it was a temptation; and it would have been. If I could pay you, señora, something of what I owe you, I believe I could only pay you in full by telling you this, for I have never spoken of it except to the one who had to hear it.³ But having

1. One of Boniface VIII's rules of canon law, in his *Regulae iuris* (Sext. V. 6). Lawrance, n. 21 [Editor].

2. 2 Corinthians 12:11.

3. This reference and the one above ("as does the only one in the world") are to her confessor, who in 1691 was likely not Antonio Núñez de Miranda (see the chronology on p. 313) [Editor].

opened wide the doors of my heart to you, revealing its deepest secrets, I want you to find my confidence worthy of what I owe to your illustrious person and excessive favors.

I

Continuing the narration of my inclination,⁴ about which I want to give you a complete account, I say that before I was three years old my mother sent an older sister of mine to learn to read in one of the primary schools for girls called *Friends*,⁵ and, led by affection and mischief, I followed after her; and seeing that she was being taught a lesson, I was so set ablaze by the desire to know how to read that in the belief I was deceiving her, I told the teacher my mother wanted her to give me a lesson too. She did not believe it, because it was not believable, but to go along with the joke, she taught me. I continued to go and she continued to teach me, in earnest now, because with experience she realized the truth; and I learned to read in so short a time that I already knew how when my mother found out, for the teacher hid it from her in order to give her complete gratification and receive her reward at the same time; and I kept silent believing I would be whipped for having done this without her knowledge. The woman who taught me is still alive (may God keep her), and she can testify to this.

I remember at this time, my appetite being what is usual at that age, I abstained from eating cheese because I had heard it made people stupid, and my desire to learn was stronger in me than the desire to eat, despite this being so powerful in children. Later, when I was six or seven years old and already knew how to read and write, along with all the other skills pertaining to sewing and needlework learned by women, I heard there was a university and schools in Mexico City where sciences were studied; as soon as I heard this I began to pester my mother with insistent, inopportune pleas that she send me, dressed as a boy, to the home of some relatives she had in Mexico City, so I could study and attend classes at the university;⁶ she refused, and rightly so, but I satisfied my desire by reading many different books owned by my grandfather, and there were not enough punishments and reprimands to stop me, so that when I came to Mexico City, people were surprised not so much by my intelligence as by my memory and the knowledge I possessed at an age when it seemed I had barely had enough time to learn to speak.

4. In Thomist teachings, a reference to a natural instinct teleologically oriented toward a divine end. This begins the section in which Sor Juana will describe her natural instinct to study such a divine impulse [Editor].

5. Primary schools for girls, called so after the school mistresses [Editor].

6. During childhood, Sor Juana lived on the outskirts of Mexico City. The Royal and Pontifical University of Mexico, founded in 1551, was restricted to male students [Editor].

I began to learn Latin and believe I had fewer than twenty lessons;⁷ my seriousness was so intense that since the natural adornment of hair is so admired in women—especially in the flower of one's youth—I would cut off four to six inches, first measuring how long it was and then imposing on myself the rule that if, when it had grown back, I did not know whatever I had proposed to learn while it was growing, I would cut it again as a punishment for my stupidity. And when it grew back and I did not know what I had determined to learn, because my hair grew quickly and I learned slowly, then in fact I did cut it as punishment for my stupidity, for it did not seem right for my head to be dressed in hair when it was so bare of knowledge, which was a more desirable adornment. I entered the convent although I knew the situation had certain characteristics (I speak of secondary qualities, not formal ones)⁸ incompatible with my character, but considering the total antipathy I had toward matrimony, the convent was the least disproportionate and most honorable decision I could make to provide the certainty I desired for my salvation, and the first (and in the end the most important) obstacle to overcome was to relinquish all the minor defects in my character, such as wanting to live alone, and not wanting any obligatory occupation that would limit the freedom of my studies, or the noise of a community that would interfere with the tranquil silence of my books. These made me hesitate somewhat in my determination, until learned persons enlightened me,⁹ saying they were a temptation, which I overcame with Divine Grace and entered into the state I so unworthily am in now. I thought I would flee myself, but I, poor wretch, brought myself with me as well as this inclination, my greatest enemy (I cannot determine whether Heaven gave it to me as a gift or a punishment), for when it was dimmed or interfered with by the many spiritual exercises present in the religious life, it exploded in me like gunpowder, proof in my own person that *privation is the cause of appetite*.¹

I returned to (no, I am wrong, for I never stopped): I mean to say I continued my studious effort (which for me was repose whenever I had time away from my obligations) to read and read some more, to study and study some more, with no teacher other than the books themselves. I learned how difficult it is to study those soulless characters without the living voice and explanations of a teacher; yet I

7. Sor Juana's Latin teacher was Martin de Olivas (see Diego Calleja, "Approval," on p. 187) [Editor].

8. Sor Juana is careful to refer to the daily routine rather than to the theological ends of the convent [Editor].

9. One of these learned persons was Father Antonio Núñez de Miranda. Sor Juana's confessor (See "Letter by Mother Juana Inés de la Cruz" on p. 144) [Editor].

1. The source for the phrase has not been identified, but it is composed of the typically scholastic terms *privatio* and *appetitus* [Editor].

gladly endured all this work for the sake of my love of letters. Oh, if it had only been for the sake of my love of God, which is the correct love, how meritorious it would have been! I did attempt to elevate it as much as I could and turn it to His service, because the goal to which I aspired was the study of theology, for, being Catholic, it seemed a foolish lack in me not to know everything that can be learned in this life, by natural means, about the Divine Mysteries; and being a nun and not a layperson, according to my ecclesiastical state I should profess vows to letters, and even more so, as a daughter of a Saint Jerome and a Saint Paula, for it seemed a deterioration if such learned parents produced an idiot child.² I proposed this to myself and it seemed correct, if it was not (and this is most likely) flattery and applause of my own inclination, its enjoyment being proposed as an obligation.

In this way I proceeded, always directing the steps of my study to the summit of sacred theology, as I have said; and to reach it, I thought it necessary to ascend by the steps of human sciences and arts, because how is one to understand the style of the queen of sciences without knowing that of the handmaidens?³ How, without logic, was I to know the general and particular methods used in the writing of Holy Scripture? How, without rhetoric, would I understand its figures, tropes, and locutions? How, without physics, comprehend the many inherent questions concerning the nature of the animals used for sacrifices, in which so many stated subjects, as well as many others that are undeclared, are symbolized? How to know whether Saul healing at the sound of David's harp came from the virtue and natural power of music or the supernatural ability God wished to place in David?⁴ How, without arithmetic, understand so many computations of years, days, months, hours, and weeks as mysterious as those in Daniel,⁵ and others for whose deciphering one must know the natures, concordances, and properties of numbers? How, without geometry, can one measure the Holy Ark of the Covenant and the holy city of Jerusalem, whose mysterious measurements form a cube with all its dimensions, a marvelous proportional distribution of all its parts?⁶ How, without architecture, fathom the

2. Sor Juana argues that as a Hieronymite nun she should be additionally bound to study. Saint Jerome (ca. 347–420 C.E.), the founder of her order, was one of the four doctors of the Church and author of the Vulgate Bible. Saint Paula was Jerome's student and co-patron of the Hieronymite convent in Mexico City. "Idiot": a reference to ignorance, especially of Latin [revised by Editor].

3. "Queen of sciences": theology (sciences referring to "knowledge"). "Handmaidens": seven liberal arts, although Sor Juana adds physics (Aristotelian natural philosophy), architecture, and history to the list of grammar, logic, rhetoric, geometry, arithmetic, music, and astronomy. Lawrance, n. 35 [Editor].

4. 1 Samuel 16:23 describes how Saul, the first king of Israel, was healed from evil spirits by the sound of the harp of David, a young soldier and future king of Israel.

5. Daniel 9:24–27.

6. Exodus 26:15–30 relates the dimensions of the Holy Ark of the Covenant, the chest that held the tablets of the Ten Commandments.

great temple of Solomon, where God Himself was the artificer, conceiving the proportion and design, and the wise king merely the overseer who executed it;⁷ where there was no base without a mystery, no column without a symbol, no cornice without an allusion, no architrave without a meaning, and so on in all its parts, so that even the smallest fillet was placed not for the service and complement of art alone but to symbolize greater things? How, without great knowledge of the rules and parts that constitute history, can the historical books⁸ be understood? Those recapitulations in which what happened earlier often is placed later in the narration and seems to have occurred afterward? How, without great familiarity with both kinds of law, can one apprehend the legal books?⁹ How, without great erudition, approach so many matters of profane history mentioned in Holy Scripture, so many Gentile customs, so many rites, so many ways of speaking? How, without many rules and much reading of the Holy Fathers,¹ can one grasp the obscure expression of the prophets? And without being very expert in music, how are we to understand the musical proportions and their beauty found in so many places, especially in the petition of Abraham to God on behalf of the cities,² that He spare them if He found fifty righteous men, and from this number he went down to forty-five, which is a *sesquinona*, going from *mi* to *re*; and from here to forty, which is a *sesquioctava*,³ going from *re* to *ut*;⁴ from here to thirty which is a *sesquitertia*, a *diatessaron*; from here to twenty, which is the *sesquialtera* proportion, a *diapente*; from

7. 1 Kings 6:2–3 relates the dimensions of the Temple of Solomon, the first temple on Mount Zion [Editor].

8. The historical books of the Old Testament (Joshua, Judges, Samuel, Kings, and Chronicles) [Editor].

9. The books of the law in the Bible are the first five, or Pentateuch, (Genesis, Exodus, Numbers, Deuteronomy, Leviticus). Law was divided into civil (state) and canon (Church) [Editor].

1. Patristic authorities, such as the Apostles, the Apostolic Fathers, and the Doctors of the Church (Ambrose, Augustine, Gregory I, and Jerome), whose interpretations of the Bible were considered authoritative [Editor].

2. Sodom and Gomorrah (Genesis 18:24–32) [Editor].

3. *Sesquinona*: a minor whole tone or minor second. *Sesquioctava*: a major whole tone or major second.

4. Modern *do*. Sor Juana apparently erred, or the text has been corrupted, when she indicated that the *sesquioctava* was from *re* to *mi*, the same illustration used for the *sesquinona*. This has been corrected to “from *re* to *ut*.” The *sesquinona* and *sesquioctava* are two different types of the interval now known as a whole tone or second. There are no modern equivalents to these two kinds of whole tones. Our thanks to Professor Mario A. Ortiz, Catholic University of America, for his invaluable assistance in clarifying the musical terminology and the Pythagorean concepts presented in this section.

As indicated by Cecil Adkins, “Monochord,” *Grove Music Online*, Oxford Music Online, Oxford University Press: “The Pythagorean concept of division by proportions is based on the relationship of the harmonic and arithmetic means as they are represented by the numbers 6, 8, 9, and 12. The ratio 12:6 produces the octave; 9:6 and 12:8, the fifth; 8:6 and 12:9, the fourth; and 9:8, the major second. Reduced to their lowest terms these ratios are dupla (12:1), *sesquialtera* (3:2), *sesquitertia* (4:3) and *sesquioctava* (9:8).”

here to ten, which is the dupla, a *diapason*;⁵ and since there are no other harmonic intervals, he went no further? Well, how could one understand this without music?⁶ In the Book of Job, God says: *Shalt thou be able to join together the shining stars the Pleiades, or canst thou stop the turning about of Arcturus?*⁷ *Canst thou bring forth the day star in its time and make the evening star to rise upon the children of the earth?*⁸ The terms, without knowledge of astronomy, would be impossible to comprehend. And not only these noble sciences, but there is no mechanical art⁹ that is not mentioned. In short, it is the book that encompasses all books, and the science that includes all sciences, which are useful for its understanding; even after learning all of them (which clearly is not easy, or even possible), another consideration demands more than all that has been said, and that is constant prayer and purity in one's life, in order to implore God for the purification of spirit and enlightenment of mind necessary for comprehending these lofty matters; if this is lacking, the rest is useless.

The Church says these words regarding the angelic doctor Saint Thomas: *When he read the most difficult passages of Holy Scripture, he combined fasting with prayer. And he would say to his companion, Brother Reginald, that all he knew was not due to study or his own labor, but that he had received it from God.*¹ And I, so distant from virtue and from letters, how was I to have the courage to write? Therefore, having attained a few elementary skills, I continually studied a variety of subjects, not having an inclination toward one in particular but toward all of them in general; as a consequence, having studied some more than others has not been by choice but because, by chance, I had access to more books about those subjects, which created the preference more than any decision of mine. And since I had no special interest that moved me, and no time limit that restricted my continuing to study one subject because of the demands of formal classes, I could study a variety of subjects or abandon some for others, although I did observe a certain order, for some I called study and others diversion, and with these I rested from the first, with the result that I have studied many subjects and know nothing, because some have interfered with my

5. *Diatessaron*: a perfect fourth. *Diapente*: a perfect fifth. *Diapason*: an octave.

6. Sor Juana was known for her musical abilities and claimed to have written a musical treatise, titled "The Shell" (*El caracol*), a manuscript that is now lost [Editor].

7. A bright star. "Pleiades": open star cluster in Taurus named after the seven daughters of the titan Atlas [Editor].

8. Job 38:31-32. "Day star": Venus. "Evening star": Mercury [Editor].

9. Mechanics was considered a commoner's craft whereas the liberal arts were noble [Editor].

1. *Roman Breviary*, Office of the Feast of Saint Thomas Aquinas, March 7, Fifth Lesson.

learning others. True, I say this regarding the practical aspect of those subjects that have one, because it is obvious that while one moves a pen, the compass does nothing, and while one plays the harp, the organ is silent, and so on; because since a great deal of physical practice is necessary to acquire a practical skill, the person who is divided among various exercises can never achieve perfection; but the opposite happens in formal and speculative areas, and I would like to persuade everyone with my experience that this not only does not interfere but helps, for one subject illuminates and opens a path in another by means of variations and hidden connections—placed in this universal chain by the wisdom of its Author—so that it seems they correspond and are joined with admirable unity and harmony. It is the chain the ancients imagined issuing from the mouth of Jupiter, where all things hung linked to all other things. Reverend Father Athanasius Kircher² demonstrates this in his curious book *On the Magnet*. All things emanate from God, Who is at once the center and circumference from which all created lines emerge and where they end.³

As for me, I can state that what I do not understand in an author from one discipline I usually can understand in a different author from another discipline that seems quite distant from the first; and in their explanations, these authors offer metaphorical examples from other arts, as when logicians say that the mean is to the terms as a measurement is to two distant bodies, in order to determine whether they are equal; and that the statement of a logician moves, like a straight line, along the shortest path, while that of a rhetorician follows, like a curve, the longest, but both travel to the same point; and when it is said that expositors are like an open hand and scholastics like a closed fist.⁴ This is not an excuse for having studied a diversity of subjects, nor do I offer it as such, for these subjects contribute to one another, but my not having benefited from them has been the fault of my ineptitude and the weakness in my understanding, not of their variety.

2. A Jesuit polymath (1602–1680) based in Rome. Heavily influenced by Neoplatonic sources, he was the author of some forty books covering subjects ranging from Egyptology to volcanoes. "The chain": the image of the golden chain emanating from Jupiter's mouth appears in Homer, *Iliad*, Book VIII [Editor].

3. *De Magnete* was the title of William Gilbert's 1600 treatise but Sor Juana appears to refer to Kircher's *Magneticum Naturae Regnum* (Magnetic realm of nature, 1667) as the source of the common Neoplatonic conceit of the "great chain of being." The idea that God is the center and circumference of the universe is derived from the German theologian Nicholas of Cusa (1401–1464) [Editor].

4. That is, logicians are scholastic syllogists who reason through a middle term, while rhetoricians are orators, and therefore work through a curved line; expositors are interpreters, and thus work to open a text, while scholastics analyze and thus reduce it to a closed position. Lawrance, n. 50 [Editor].

II

What might absolve me is the immense amount of work caused by lacking not only a teacher but other students with whom to confer and practice what I studied, having a mute book for a teacher and an insentient inkwell for a fellow student; and instead of explanation and practice, countless obstacles, not only those of my religious obligations (and we already know what a helpful and profitable use of time these are) but those other things that are inevitable in a community: for instance, when I am reading and in the adjoining cell they take a notion to play their instruments and sing; when I am studying and two maidservants have a quarrel and come to have me judge their dispute; when I am writing and a friend comes to visit, doing me a disservice with nothing but good intentions, and it is necessary not only to accept the intrusion but be grateful for the damage done. And this happens constantly, because since the times I devote to my studies are those not dedicated to the routine duties of the community, those same times are moments of leisure for the other sisters who interrupt me; and only those who have experienced communal life know how true this is, for only the strength of my vocation and the great love that exists among me and my beloved sisters can make my disposition agreeable, and since love is harmony, in it there are no polar opposites.⁵

I do confess that my work has been interminable, which means I cannot say what I enviously hear others say: that they have not had to work for knowledge. How fortunate for them! For me, not the knowing (for I still know nothing) but only the desire to know has been so difficult that I could say with my father Saint Jerome (although not with his achievements): *The labor it has cost me, the difficulties I have endured, the times I have despaired, and the other times I have desisted and begun again, all because of my determination to learn, to what I have suffered my conscience is witness and the conscience of those who have lived with me.*⁶ Except for the companions and witnesses (for I have lacked even that solace), I can affirm the truth of the rest. And that my unfortunate inclination has been so great it has overcome everything else!

It used to happen that since a kind, affable temperament is one of the many benefits I owe to God, the other nuns were very fond of me (without noticing, like the good women they are, my faults) and as a consequence they enjoyed my company; knowing this, and moved by the great love I had for them, with more reason than they had for loving me, I enjoyed their company even more; and so, during

5. That is, her love for her convent sisters overcomes their extreme differences [Editor].

6. Letter CXXV from Saint Jerome to the monk Rusticus (411 C.E.).

the times all of us had free, I would go to cheer them and take pleasure in their conversation. I noticed that during these times I lost the opportunity to study, and I vowed not to enter any cell unless obliged to by obedience or charity, because without this severe restraint, the deterrent of mere intention would be broken by my love; and this vow (knowing my weakness) I would make for a month or for two weeks; and when it was fulfilled I would renew it, giving myself a day or two of respite and using that time not so much for rest (for not studying has never been restful to me) as for keeping my dearly loved sisters from thinking me harsh, withdrawn, and ungrateful for their undeserved affection.

It is clear from this how strong my inclination is. I thank God for willing that it be turned to letters and not another vice, for it was practically unconquerable; and it can easily be inferred how my poor studies have sailed against the current (or rather, how they have foundered). For I still have not recounted the most arduous of the difficulties; those I have described so far have been merely obligatory or accidental obstacles, and therefore indirect. I have not touched on the direct ones whose intent was to interfere with and prevent my studies. Who would not think, seeing the widespread acclaim I have received, that I sailed calm seas with the wind behind me, surrounded by the applause of general approbation? But God knows it has not been so, because among the flowers of these same acclamations more serpents than I can count of rivalries and persecutions have arisen and awakened, and the most noxious and hurtful to me have been not those who persecuted me with open hatred and malice but those who, loving me and desiring my welfare (and perhaps deserving a great deal from God for their good intentions), mortified and tormented me more than the others, saying: "Her studies are not in accord with holy ignorance; she will surely be lost, and at such heights her own perspicacity and wit are bound to make her vain." What did it cost me to endure this? A strange kind of martyrdom, in which I was both the martyr and my own executioner!

As for my ability—doubly unfortunate in me—to compose verses, even if religious, what sorrows has it not caused me, and causes me still? In truth, señora, at times I begin to think that the one who excels—or is made to excel by God, Who alone can effect this—is received as a common enemy, because it seems to some that this person usurps the applause they deserve or blocks the admiration to which they aspire, and so they persecute this person.

That politically barbarous law of Athens, by which whoever excelled in gifts and virtues was exiled from the republic to keep him from tyrannizing public liberty with those gifts, still endures and is still observed in our day, although the motive of the Athenians no longer exists; but there is another one, no less effective although not

as well founded, for it seems a maxim of the impious Machiavelli and that is to despise the one who excels because that person discredits others.⁷ This occurs, and has always occurred.

If this is not so, what caused the rabid hatred of the Pharisees⁸ toward Christ, when there were so many reasons for them to feel otherwise? For if we consider His presence, what gift was more worthy of love than His divine beauty? What gift more powerful in captivating hearts? If human comeliness rules our wills, and with tender and desired force knows how to subject them, what would be the effect of His beauty with its countless prerogatives and sovereign charms? What would that incomprehensible comeliness do, what would it move, what would it not do and not move, when from that beautiful face, as if from polished crystal, the beams of Divinity shone through? What could that countenance not move, when above and beyond incomparable human perfections, it also disclosed illuminations of the divine? If the face of Moses, after only conversing with God, proved unendurable to the fragility of human eyes,⁹ what would the humanized face of God Himself be like? And if we turn to His other gifts, what more worthy of love than that celestial modesty, that gentleness and tenderness pouring forth mercy in all His movements, that profound humility and compassion, those words of eternal life and eternal wisdom? How is it possible that all of this did not stir their souls to follow Him, did not elevate them and fill them with love?

My holy mother Saint Teresa¹ says that after she saw the beauty of Christ, she could never again feel an inclination toward any creature because she saw nothing that was not ugly compared to that beauty. How could it have had such contrary effects in men? And even if they were rough and base and had no knowledge of or esteem for His perfections, not even as possibly profitable, how could they not be moved by the advantage and usefulness of all the benefits received from Him: healing the sick, resuscitating the dead, curing those possessed by the devil?² How could they not love Him? Oh, God, that was precisely why they did not love Him, that was precisely why they despised Him! They themselves bore witness to that.

7. The works of Niccolò Machiavelli (1469–1527) were on the Spanish Inquisition's index of prohibited books. Sor Juana most likely only knew of the Italian political theorist through his negative reputation among the political theorists of the Spanish monarchy, for whom Machiavelli was synonymous with governance that ignored Christian principles. "Barbarous law": Aristotle, *Athenian Constitution*, Chapter 22, recounts the democratic practice of ostracism, by which a yearly convention exiled those who had become too strong [Editor].

8. One of the three major societies of Judaism and responsible, according to Matthew 12:14 and Mark 3:6, for a plot to kill Jesus Christ [Editor].

9. Exodus 34:29–30.

1. Saint Teresa of Ávila (1515–1582), a Spanish mystic. Lawrance identifies a possible source for the reference in her autobiography, *The Life*, Chapter 37. Lawrance, n. 63 [Editor].

2. Christ's miracles [Editor].

They met in their council and said: *What do we? For this man doeth many miracles.*³ Can this be a motive? If they had said: "This man is a malefactor, a transgressor against the law, an agitator who with deceptions stirs up the people," they would have lied, as they lied when they did say these things; yet there were more coherent reasons for doing what they asked, which was to take His life, but to give as a reason that He performed miracles does not seem worthy of learned men, which the Pharisees were. And so it is that when learned men are overcome by passion, they spew forth these kinds of irrelevancies. Indeed, only for that reason was it determined that Christ should die. Men, if I can call you that when you are so brutish, what was the reason for so cruel a determination? Their only response is *multa signa facit.*⁴ Lord have mercy if doing excellent things is a reason to die! This *multa signa facit* evokes *there shall be a root of Jesse, which shall stand for an ensign of the people* and then *to this child . . . [is] a sign which shall be spoken against.*⁵ He is a sign? Then He must die! He excels? Then He must suffer, for that is the reward of one who excels!

Figures of the winds and of fame are usually placed at the very top of temples as decoration, and to protect them from birds, they are covered by barbs; this seems a protection yet is nothing but an inevitable attribute: whoever is on high is necessarily pierced by barbs. The animosity of the wind is there, the severity of the elements, the fury of thunderbolts taking their revenge, there is the target of stones and arrows. Oh unhappy heights, exposed to so many risks! Oh excellence, made a target of envy and the object of hostility! Any eminence, whether of dignity, nobility, wealth, beauty, or knowledge, suffers this burden, but the one that suffers most severely is understanding. First, because it is the most defenseless, since wealth and power punish any who attacks them, but not understanding, for the greater it is, the more modest and long-suffering and the less it defends itself. Second, because as Gracián⁶ so wisely said, the advantages of understanding are advantages in one's being. For no other reason than greater understanding are angels more than men; and men surpass brutes only in understanding; and since no one wants to be less than another, no man confesses that another understands more, because that is the consequence of being more. A man will suffer and confess that another is more noble than he, wealthier, handsomer, and even more learned; but there is hardly

3. John 11:47.

4. A repetition of the last phrase of John 11:47, from the Vulgate Bible: "[this man] doeth many miracles" or "*signa*" in Latin [Editor].

5. "There shall be a root": Isaiah 11:10. "This child": Luke 2:34.

6. Baltasar Gracián (1601-1658), influential Spanish Jesuit moralist. The phrase is found in his *El discreto* (The gentleman, 1646), I: "Nature and Intelligence" [Editor].

anyone who will confess that another has more understanding: rare is the man who will concede cleverness.⁷ That is why attacks against this gift are so effective.

When the soldiers mocked and jeered and taunted Our Lord Jesus Christ, they brought an old purple cloth and a hollow reed and a crown of thorns to crown Him a derisory king.⁸ Now, the reed and the purple cloth were insulting, but not painful; why was only the crown painful? Was it not enough that, like the other emblems, it would be mocking and ignominious, since that was its purpose? No, because the sacred head of Christ and His divine brain were the repository of wisdom; and it is not enough in the world for a wise brain to be ridiculed, it must also be wounded and mistreated; a head that is a treasury of wisdom should not expect any crown other than one of thorns. What garland can human wisdom expect when it sees what divine wisdom received? Roman pride also crowned the various feats of its captains with various crowns: the civic for the man who defended the city, the military for the man who penetrated the enemy camp, the mural for the man who scaled the wall, the obsidional for the man who freed a besieged city or army or field or camp, the naval, the oval, the triumphal for other deeds, as recounted by Pliny and Aulus Gellius;⁹ but considering so many different kinds of crowns, I wondered which type was used for the crown of Christ, and I think it was the obsidional, which (as you know, señora) was the most honorable and called obsidional from *obsidio*, which means "siege"; it was not made of gold or silver but of the very grain or grass growing in the field where the feat was accomplished. And since the feat of Christ was to raise the siege of the Prince of Darkness,¹ who had besieged all the world, as it says in the Book of Job: *From going to and fro in the earth, and from walking up and down in it*; and as Saint Peter says: *the devil . . . walketh about, seeking whom he may devour*;² and Our Lord came and raised the siege: *now shall the prince of this world be cast out*, and so the soldiers crowned Him not with gold or silver but with the natural fruit produced by the world, which was the battlefield that, after the curse, *thorns and thistles shall it bring forth to thee*,³ produced nothing but thorns; therefore it was the most suitable crown for the valiant and wise Conqueror, crowned by His mother the Synagogue; and the daughters of Zion came out weeping to see His sorrowful triumph, as they had come rejoicing for

7. A paraphrase of Martial (ca. 40–104 C.E.), *Epigrammata*, VIII.xviii.10: *qui velit ingenio cedere, rarus erit* (He who is willing to cede to genius will be rare) [Editor].

8. Matthew 27:28–29 [Editor].

9. Aulus Gellius (ca. 125–180 C.E.), *Attic Nights*, V.vi. Pliny the Elder (23–79 C.E.), *Natural History*, XXII.iv.6–vi.13 [Editor].

1. That is, Satan [Editor].

2. "From going to and fro": Job 1:7 (KJV). "The devil": 1 Peter 5:8.

3. "Now shall the prince": John 12:31. "Thorns also": Genesis 3:18.

the other Solomon, because the triumph of the wise is achieved with sorrow and celebrated with weeping,⁴ which is how wisdom triumphs; and since Christ, as the King of Wisdom, was the first to wear the crown that was made holy on His temples, other wise men are no longer afraid and understand they cannot aspire to any other honor.

Life Himself wished to give life to the deceased Lazarus;⁵ the Disciples were not aware of His intention and replied: *Master, the Jews of late sought to stone thee; and goest thou thither again?* The Redeemer assuaged their fear: *Are there not twelve hours in the day?*⁶ Up to this point it seems they were afraid because of the antecedent of the people wanting to stone Him when He reproached them, calling them thieves and not shepherds.⁷ And so they feared that if He returned to the same place (since no matter how just, rebukes are not often acknowledged as true), He would put His life in danger; but when they knew the truth and realized He was going to give life to Lazarus, what reason could have moved Thomas to say, as did Peter in the garden: *Let us also go, that we may die with him?*⁸ What are you saying, Holy Apostle? The Lord is not going to die; what do you fear? For Christ is not going to reprove but to perform an act of mercy, and therefore they cannot do Him harm. The Jews themselves could have reassured you, for when He rebuked them for wanting to stone him: *Many good works have I shewed you from my Father; for which of those works do you stone me?* They replied: *For a good work we stone thee not; but for blasphemy.*⁹ For if they say they do not wish to stone him for His good works, and now He is going to perform one as good as giving life to Lazarus, what is it you fear, or why? Would it not be better to say: *Let us go to enjoy the fruits of gratitude for the good work our Master is going to perform; to see Him applauded and thanked for the benefit; to see their wonderment at the miracle? And not to say what appears to be as irrelevant as: Eamus et nos, ut moriamur cum eo.*¹ But oh! The saint feared as an intelligent man and spoke as an Apostle.² Is Christ not going to perform a miracle? Well, what greater danger? It is less intolerable for pride to hear rebukes than for envy to see miracles. In everything I have said, illustrious señora, I do not wish to say (let no such foolishness find a place in me) that I have been persecuted for knowing, but only for loving knowledge and letters, because I have achieved neither.

4. Song of Solomon 3:10–11. "Daughters of Zion": Luke 23:27–29 [Editor].

5. See John 11. "Life Himself": Christ [Editor].

6. John 11:8–9. That is, there was still time, although Jesus was near death [revised by Editor].

7. John 10:1–18 [Editor].

8. John 11:16.

9. John 10:32–33.

1. "Let us also go, that we may die with him." John 11:16 as cited above [Editor].

2. That is, Saint Thomas, who has spoken the phrase to John [Editor].

At one time the Prince of the Apostles³ found himself so distant from wisdom it was indicated with an emphatic: *But Peter followed afar off*; as far from the praise of the learned man as one known for his lack of intelligence: *Not knowing what he said*; and even questioned regarding his knowledge of wisdom, he himself said he knew nothing of it: *Woman, I know him not. Man, I know not what thou sayest*. And what happens to him? As a result of being known as an ignorant man, he did not have the good fortune of a wise man but only the afflictions. Why? No reason was given other than: *This man was also with him*.⁴ He loved wisdom, carried it in his heart, followed after it, valued being a follower and lover of wisdom; and although he was so far off that he did not understand or reach it, it was enough to incur its torments. There was always a foreign soldier to cause him distress, a maidservant to trouble him. I confess I find myself very far from the boundaries of wisdom and have wanted to follow it, although at a distance. Yet this has brought me closer to the fire of persecution, the crucible of torment, to the extent that some have requested that I be forbidden to study.

This once was achieved by a very saintly, very ingenuous mother superior who believed that study was a matter for the Inquisition and ordered me to stop. I obeyed (for the three months her power to command lasted) in that I did not pick up a book, but not studying at all, which is not in my power, I could not do, because although I did not study books, I studied all the things God created, and these were my letters, and my book was the entire mechanism of the universe. I saw nothing without reflecting on it, heard nothing without considering it, even the smallest material things, for there is no creature, no matter how low, in which one does not recognize *God created me*,⁵ none that does not astonish the understanding, if one considers it as one should. And so, I repeat, I looked at and admired everything; as a consequence, even the people to whom I spoke, and the things they said to me, gave rise to a thousand considerations: What is the origin of the varieties of intelligence and wit, since we are all one species? What could be the temperaments and hidden qualities that caused them? If I saw a figure, I would combine the proportion of its lines and measure it with my understanding and reduce it to other, different figures. I would walk sometimes in the front part of our dormitory (which is a very spacious room) and observe that while the lines of its two sides were parallel and the ceiling level, the eye made it seem that its lines inclined toward each other and the

3. The Apostle Peter [Editor].

4. "And Peter": Luke 22:54. "Not knowing": Luke 9:33. "Woman": Luke 22:57, 60. "This man": Luke 22:56.

5. The source is most likely Saint Augustine, *Sermones*, 68, 6, a meditation on the "book of nature" [Editor].

ceiling was lower at a distance than nearby, and from this I inferred that visual lines run straight, not parallel, but form a pyramidal shape instead. And I wondered whether this might be the reason the ancients were obliged to doubt the world was round. Because although it seems so, our sight could deceive us, showing concavities where there might not be any.

I notice everything in this manner and always have and have no control over it; in fact it tends to annoy me, for it wearies my head; I thought this, and composing verses, happened to everyone, until experience showed me the contrary; and this is so much my character or custom that I see nothing without considering it further. Two little girls were playing with a top in my presence, and no sooner did I see the movement and shape than I began, with this madness of mine, to consider the easy motion of the spherical shape and how the already transmitted impulse could last, independent of its cause, for far from the hand of the little girl, which was the motivating cause, the top still danced; not content with this, I had some flour brought in and sifted, so that as the top danced on top of it, I could learn whether the circles described by its movement were perfect or not; and I found that they were merely spiral lines that lost their circular nature as the impulse diminished. Some other girls were playing jackstraws (which is the most frivolous of children's games); I began to contemplate the figures they formed, and seeing that by chance three fell into a triangle, I began to connect one to the other, recalling that some say this was the shape of the mysterious ring of Solomon, which had distant indications and representations of the Holy Trinity, allowing him to perform countless miracles and marvels; and it is said that the harp of David⁶ had the same shape, and for that reason Saul was healed at its sound; harps in our day still have almost the same shape.

And what could I tell you, señora, about the natural secrets I have discovered when cooking? Seeing that an egg sets and fries in butter or oil but falls apart in syrup; seeing that for sugar to remain liquid it is enough to add a very small amount of water in which a quince or other bitter fruit has been placed; seeing that the yolk and the white of the same egg are so different that each can be mixed with sugar but together they cannot. I do not mean to tire you with these inconsequentialities, which I mention only to give you a complete view of my nature, and which I believe will cause you to laugh; but, señora, what can we women know but kitchen philosophies? As Lupericio Leonardo⁷

6. See p. 98, n. 4. "Ring of Solomon": inscribed with the secret name of God and shaped as a star of David [Editor].

7. Lupericio Leonardo de Argensola (1559-1613), but the citation's source is actually Luperico's brother Bartolomé Leonardo de Argensola, *Satire* I.143-44. Lawrance, n. 83 [revised by Editor].

so wisely said, one can philosophize very well and prepare supper. And seeing these minor details, I say that if Aristotle had cooked, he would have written a great deal more. Returning to my continual cogitation, I repeat that this is so constant in me I do not need books; on one occasion, because of a serious stomach ailment, the doctors prohibited my studying; after a few days I suggested to them that it would be less harmful to allow me books, because my cogitations were so strong and vehement that they consumed more energy in a quarter of an hour than studying books did in four days; and so they were persuaded to allow me to read. And further, señora: not even my sleep was free of this continual movement of my imaginative faculty; rather, it tends to operate more freely and unencumbered, examining with greater clarity and tranquility the images of the day, arguing, and composing verses, and I could offer you a large catalogue of them and the arguments and delicate points I have formulated more successfully asleep than awake, but I put those aside in order not to weary you, for what I have said is enough for your intelligence and perspicacity to penetrate and see perfectly my entire nature, as well as the origin, means, and state of my studies.

If these, señora, are merits (I see them celebrated as such in men), they would not be so in me, because I act out of necessity. If they are blameworthy, for the same reason I believe I am not at fault; nonetheless, I am so wary of myself that in this or anything else I do not trust my own judgment; and so I remit the decision to your sovereign talent, submitting to whatever sentence you may impose, without contradiction or opposition, for this has been no more than a simple narration of my inclination toward letters.

III

I confess as well that since this is so true, as I have said, I needed no examples, yet the many I have read, in both divine and human letters, have not failed to help me. For I find Deborah⁸ issuing laws, both military and political, and governing a people that had many learned men. I find an exceedingly wise Queen of Sheba,⁹ so learned she dares to test with enigmas the wisdom of the greatest of wise men and is not rebuked for that reason; instead, because of it, she becomes judge of the unbelievers. I find numerous illustrious women: some adorned with the gift of prophecy, like Abigail; others, with the gift of persuasion, like Esther; others, with piety, like Rahab; others,

8. Female judge of ancient Israel, named in Judges 4-5.

9. Wealthy queen who visited King Solomon to test his wisdom and bestow gifts, as described in 1 Kings 10.

with perseverance, like Hannah, mother of Samuel, and countless others possessing all kinds of gifts and virtues.¹

If I turn to the Gentiles, I first encounter the Sibyls,² chosen by God to prophesy the principal mysteries of our faith, in verses so learned and elegant they enthrall our admiration. I find a woman like Minerva,³ daughter of the foremost god Jupiter and mistress of all the knowledge of Athens, worshipped as goddess of the sciences. I find Polla Argentaria,⁴ who helped Lucan, her husband, write the great *Pharsalia*. I find the daughter of the divine Tiresias,⁵ more learned than her father. I find Zenobia, queen of the Palmyrenes, as wise as she was valiant. Arete,⁶ the most learned daughter of Aristippus. Nicostrata,⁷ inventor of Latin characters and extremely erudite in Greek ones. Aspasia of Miletus,⁸ who taught philosophy and rhetoric and was the tutor of the philosopher Pericles.⁹ Hypatia, who taught astronomy and studied for many years in Alexandria. Leontion,¹ a Greek woman who wrote arguments countering the philosopher Theophrastus, which convinced him. Jucia, Corinna, Cornelia,² in short, all the great number of women who deserved fame, whether as Greeks, muses, or pythonesses,³ for all of them were simply learned women, considered and celebrated and also venerated as such in antiquity. Not to mention countless others who fill the books, for I find the Egyptian Catherine⁴ studying and affecting

1. Abigail: Prophet who becomes the wife of King David in 1 Samuel 25. Esther: Jewish queen of Persia (wife of Ahasuerus) who risked her life to save Jewish citizens from slaughter by the vizier Haman, as described in the Book of Esther. Rahab: Prostitute who helped the Israelites take Jericho by hiding spies in her home, as described in Joshua 2. Hannah, mother of Samuel, conceived miraculously at an advanced age, as described in 1 Samuel 1.
2. In ancient Greece, the women oracles who prophesied through a frenzied trance. They were known through the Sibylline books, in Greek hexameter, consulted in Rome at moments of crisis, and as Sor Juana suggests commonly reputed to have prophesied Christianity [Editor].
3. Roman goddess of wisdom, born of the head of Jupiter [Editor].
4. Widow of the poet Lucan and greatly admired by the poet Statius who calls her "patron of the arts" in his *Silvae* 2.7 [Editor].
5. In Greek mythology, a blind prophet who was transformed into a woman for seven years. His daughter was Manto, as recounted in Ovid, *Metamorphoses*, 6.7 [revised by Editor].
6. Said to have founded a school of philosophy (4th century B.C.E.). Zenobia: (ca. 240–275 C.E.), queen of the Palmyrene empire in Syria, she conquered Egypt and led a revolt against Rome [revised by Editor].
7. Legendary woman of letters said to have devised the first fifteen letters of the Latin alphabet [Editor].
8. Learned woman (ca. 470–410 B.C.E.) who became the mistress of Pericles [Editor].
9. Hypatia (ca. 370–415 C.E.), Neoplatonist and mathematician in Roman Egypt.
1. Greek Epicurean philosopher (4th–3rd century B.C.E.) who wrote against Theophrastus, according to Cicero, *De Natura Deorum* (On the Nature of the Gods) [revised by Editor].
2. For Jucia, Sor Juana may have meant Julia (Domna), an intellectual Roman empress. Corinna (active 5th century B.C.E.): ancient Greek poet, thought by some to be a contemporary of Pindar. Cornelia (2nd century C.E.): early Catholic saint and martyr.
3. Greek priestesses [Editor].
4. Catherine of Alexandria (active 4th century C.E.), scholar and virgin saint [revised by Editor].

all the wisdom of the wise men of Egypt. I find Gertrude⁵ reading, writing, and teaching. And for examples closer to home, I find a most holy mother of mine, Paula,⁶ learned in the Hebrew, Greek, and Latin languages and extremely skilled in interpreting Scripture. And none other than the great Saint Jerome scarcely thought himself worthy of being her chronicler, for with the lively thought and energetic exactitude he brings to his explanations, he says: *If all the members of my body were tongues, they would not suffice to publish the wisdom and virtue of Paula.*⁷ The widow Blasilla deserved the same praise, as did the illustrious virgin Eustochium, both daughters of this saint; the second, for her knowledge, was called Prodigy of the World.⁸ Fabiola, a Roman woman, was also extremely learned in Holy Scripture.⁹ Proba Faltonia, another Roman, wrote an elegant book, a cento of selections from Virgil, on the mysteries of our Holy Faith.¹ It is well known that our queen, Doña Isabel, the wife of Alfonso X,² wrote on astronomy. And many others whom I omit in order not to cite what others have said (a vice I have always despised), for in our day the great Christina Alexandra, Queen of Sweden, as learned as she is valiant and magnanimous, and the Most Honorable Ladies the Duchess of Aveiro and the Countess of Vil-laumbrosa³ are all flourishing.

The illustrious Doctor Arce⁴ (a professor of Scripture, eminent for his virtue and learning), in his *Studio Bibliorum*, raises this question: *Is it legitimate for women to dedicate themselves to the study of Holy Scripture and its interpretation?* And he offers many judgments of saints that argue against this, in particular the statement of the Apostle: *Let your women keep silence in the churches: for it is not*

5. Saint Gertrude of Helfta (1256–1302), German mystic and Benedictine theologian [revised by Editor].

6. Saint Paula (347–404 C.E.): wealthy Roman woman who became a Desert Mother, companion of Saint Jerome, and co-patron of the Hieronymite Order.

7. The first sentence of Saint Jerome's letter to Eustochium (*Letter* 108.1).

8. Blasilla (d. 384) and Eustochium (ca. 368–420 C.E.) were daughters of Saint Paula. Blasilla died young, while Eustochium became a saint and a Desert Mother.

9. Fabiola (d. 399 C.E.): Roman noblewoman who became a follower of Saint Jerome and Saint Paula.

1. Proba Faltonia (ca. 4th century C.E.): Roman Christian poet.

2. Apparently, Sor Juana commits an error. The wife of Alfonso X was Violante of Aragon, who did collaborate on Alfonso's astronomical treatises. Doña Isabel was the wife and queen of Ferdinand V [Editor].

3. An Andalusian Dominican nun. Christina Alexandra (1626–1689), Queen of Sweden with an interest in philosophy and science. She was a patroness of René Descartes and others. Duchess of Aveiro (1630–1715), a member of the Portuguese royalty and friend of the Countess of Paredes, vicereine of New Spain. Sor Juana dedicated a poem to her [revised by Editor].

4. Doctor Juan Díaz de Arce (1594–1653), professor of theology at the Royal and Pontifical University of Mexico and archbishop of Santo Domingo. Sor Juana refers to his argument in *Quaestionarii expositivi liber quartus de studioso bibliorum* (Expositive inquiries, Book four of concerning a student of books, 1648) [Editor].

*permitted unto them to speak,*⁵ et cetera. Then he offers other judgments, including one by the same Apostle in Titus: *The aged women likewise, that they be in behavior as becometh holiness . . . teachers of good things,*⁶ with interpretations of the holy fathers; and finally he prudently resolves that giving public lectures from a professor's chair and preaching from a pulpit are not legitimate for women, but that studying, writing, and teaching privately not only are legitimate but very advantageous and useful; it is obvious that this does not apply to all women but only to those whom God has favored with special virtue and prudence, who are mature and erudite and have the necessary talent and requisites for so sacred an occupation. And this is true not only for women, who are considered to be so incompetent, but for men as well, who for the simple fact of being men think they are wise: the interpretation of Scripture should be forbidden unless the men are very learned and virtuous, with tractable, well-inclined natures; I believe that doing otherwise has resulted in countless sectarians and has been at the root of countless heresies, for there are many who study but remain ignorant, especially those whose natures are arrogant, restless, proud, and inclined toward innovations in religion (which turns away from innovations); and so, in order to say what no one else has said, they are not content until they utter a heresy. About them the Holy Spirit declares: *For wisdom will not enter into a malicious soul.*⁷ Knowledge does these men more harm than ignorance would. A wise man said that the man who does not know Latin is not a complete fool, but the one who does is qualified to be one. And I would like to add that a fool becomes perfect (if foolishness can reach perfection) by studying his bit of philosophy and theology and having some idea of languages, making him a fool in many sciences and many languages, because a great fool cannot be contained in his mother tongue alone.

These men, I repeat, are harmed by studying because it places a sword in the hands of a madman; being a noble instrument for defense, in his hands it means his death and the death of many others. This is what divine letters became in the hands of the wicked Pelagius and the perverse Arius, the wicked Luther, and the other heresiarchs like our Doctor (he was never ours and never a doctor) Cazalla,⁸ all of them harmed by knowledge because, although it is the best nourishment and life of the soul, just as the better the food

5. 1 Corinthians 14:34 (KJV). Sor Juana directly addresses the bishop's argument in "Letter from Sor Filotea" (see p. 87, n. 8).

6. Titus 2:3 (KJV). "Same Apostle": Paul [revised by Editor].

7. Wisdom 1:4.

8. Doctor Agustín Cazalla (1510–1559), confessor to Charles V and burned at the stake by the Inquisition for Lutheranism. Pelagius (ca. 354–ca. 430 C.E.), British-Roman ascetic and theologian who opposed the theory of predestination, instead emphasizing individual free will. Arius (ca. 250–336 C.E.), Alexandrian ascetic and theologian who

in an unbalanced, overheated stomach, the more arid, fermented, and perverse the humors⁹ it creates, so it is with these evil men, for the more they study the worse the opinions they engender; their understanding is blocked by the very thing that should have nourished them, for they study a great deal and digest very little, not taking into account the limited vessel of their understanding. Regarding this the Apostle says: *For I say, by the grace that is given me, to all that are among you, not to be more wise than it behoveth to be wise, but to be wise unto sobriety, and according as God hath divided to everyone the measure of faith.*¹ And the truth is that the Apostle did not say this to women but to men; the *taceant*² is not only for women but for all those who are not very capable. My wanting to know as much as or more than Aristotle or Saint Augustine, if I do not have the aptitude of Saint Augustine or Aristotle, means that even if I study more than both of them, I not only will not succeed in my ambition, but the lack of proportion in my purpose will weaken and confuse the operation of my weak understanding.

Oh, if all of us—and I before anyone, for I am an ignorant woman—would take the measure of our talent before studying and (what is worse) writing with a voracious desire to equal and even surpass others, how little ambition would we have left and how many errors would we avoid and how many twisted intelligences would we not have in the world! And I place mine in first place, for if I knew as much as I should, I would not be writing this. And I insist I am doing so only to obey you, with so much misgiving that you owe me more for taking up my pen, having this fear, than you would if I had sent you more perfect works. It is good that this will be corrected by you; erase it, tear it up, and reprimand me, for I will value that more than all the vain applause others may offer me: *The just man shall correct me in mercy, and shall reprove me; but let not the oil of the sinner fatten my head.*³

And returning to our Arce, I say that he offers as confirmation of his opinion the words of my father Saint Jerome (*To Leta*,⁴ *Upon the Education of her Daughter*) where he says: *Accustom her tongue while she is still young to the sweetness of the Psalms. Even the names through which she gradually will become accustomed to form her phrases*

opposed the doctrine of the Trinity, instead declaring Christ to be subordinate to God the Father. Martin Luther (1483–1546), German monk and theologian who advocated that salvation is by faith alone, and prompted the Protestant Reformation by challenging the pope's authority [revised by Editor].

9. In Hippocratic medicine, the four humors (black bile, yellow bile, blood, and phlegm) must be balanced for health. Imbalance would lead to a choleric (hot and dry) stomach [Editor].

1. Romans 12:3. "The Apostle": Paul [revised by Editor].

2. "Keep silence" (see p. 87, n. 8).

3. Psalm 141:5 [Editor].

4. The daughter-in-law of Saint Paula. Leta's daughter was also named Paula [Editor].

should not be chosen by chance but selected and repeated with care; the prophets must be included, of course, and the Apostles as well, and all the Patriarchs beginning with Adam down to Matthew and Luke, so that as she practices other things she will be readying her memory for the future. Let your daily task be taken from the flower of the Scriptures.⁵ If the saint wanted a little girl who had barely begun to speak to be educated in this way, what would he want in his nuns and spiritual daughters? It is known very well in the above mentioned Eustochium and Fabiola and in Marcella, her sister Pacatula, and others whom the saint honors in his letters, exhorting them to this sacred exercise, as it is known in the cited letter where I noted that *reddat tibi pensum*, which affirms and agrees with the *bene docentes* of Saint Paul, for the *reddat tibi*⁶ of my great father makes it plain that the teacher of the little girl is to be Leta, her mother.

Oh, how much harm could be averted in our republic if older women were as learned as Leta and knew how to teach as Saint Paul and my father Saint Jerome advise! Since they do not, and given the extreme idleness in which our unfortunate women are left, if some parents wish to give their daughters more instruction than usual, necessity and the lack of learned older women obliges them to have male tutors teach their daughters how to read, write, count, play an instrument, and other skills, which results in a good amount of harm, as we see every day in lamentable examples of mismatched unions, for over time, with close dealings and communication, what was thought impossible tends to become conceivable. For this reason many parents choose to leave their daughters unlettered⁷ and uneducated rather than expose them to so notable a danger as familiarity with men, which could be avoided if there were learned older women, as Saint Paul desires, and instruction would be handed down from one female to another as occurs in the teaching of needlework and other customary skills.

For what disadvantage can there be in having an older woman learned in letters, whose conversation and customs are holy, directing the education of young girls? The alternative is allowing them to be lost through lack of instruction, or wishing to teach them by means as dangerous as male tutors, even when there is no more risk than the indecency of having a shy girl (who still blushes when her

5. Sor Juana combines three separate passages from Saint Jerome's *Letter to Laeta* (Letter 107.4, 9) [Editor].

6. *reddat tibi pensum*: Let your daily task (from Saint Jerome, Letter 107.9; see previous note). Marcella (325–410 C.E.), Roman ascetic and saint who housed Saint Jerome while he translated the Bible into Latin. Saint Jerome and Saint Paula first met in her house. Jerome addresses Pacatula, Marcella's sister, in his letter to her father, Gaudentius. "*Bene docentes*": teachers of good things (from Titus 2:3; see p. 113, n. 6) [Editor].

7. Sor Juana's term is *bárbaras*, often used in the colonial context to refer to what the Spanish understood as indigenous perversion and savagery, associates civilization with reading and writing [Editor].

own father looks in her face) sit beside a strange man who will treat her with domestic familiarity and authoritative informality; the modesty required in dealings with men and their conversation is enough reason not to permit this kind of arrangement. I do not find that this form of instruction, when men teach women, can be without danger except in the severe tribunal of a confessional or the decent distance of pulpits or the remote learning from books, but not in immediate proximity. Everyone knows this is true; even so, it is allowed only because of the lack of educated older women; therefore, not having them does great harm. This should be considered by those who, attached to *Mulieres in Ecclesia* [sic] *taceant*, curse the women who learn and teach, as if the Apostle himself had not said: *bene docentes*. Moreover, the prohibition came at a time when, as Eusebius⁸ indicates, in the early Church women would teach one another doctrine in the temples, and this sound caused some confusion when the Apostles preached; that is why they were ordered to be silent, as occurs now, when one does not pray aloud while the preacher delivers his sermon.

There is no doubt that to understand many passages of divine letters, one needs to know a good deal about the history, customs, ceremonies, proverbs, and even modes of speech of the times when they were written in order to comprehend the references and allusions of certain locutions. *Rend your heart, and not your garments*,⁹ is this not an allusion to the ceremony the Hebrews had of tearing their clothes as a sign of grief, as the evil high priest did when he said that Christ had blasphemed?¹ In many passages the Apostle writes of help for widows, and did they also not refer to the customs of those times?² The passage about the strong woman: *Her husband is known in the gates, when he sitteth among the elders of the land*,³ does it not allude to the custom of holding the tribunal of judges at the gates of the cities? And *give your land to God*,⁴ did it not signify making a vow? *Hiemantes*,⁵ was this not the name given to public sinners, because they performed their penance in the open air, unlike others who repented in a covered passage? The complaint of Christ to the Pharisee regarding the lack of a kiss and the washing of his feet, was it not based on the custom the Jews had of doing

8. Greek bishop (ca. 260–340 C.E.), who wrote extensively on the early Church [Editor].

9. Joel 2:13.

1. Matthew 26:65: "Then the high priests rent his garments, saying: He hath blasphemed."

2. 1 Timothy 5:3–16 [Editor].

3. Proverbs 31:23 (KJV).

4. A phrase not found in the Bible. Sor Juana may refer to the act of turning over lands every seven years and forgiving debts in the Jubilee, as recounted in Leviticus 27:21 [Editor].

5. Penitents of the early Church, so called ("freezing") because they were required to stand outside, even in the winter [Editor].

these things?⁶ And countless other passages that one encounters constantly, not only in divine letters but in human letters as well, such as *venerate the purple*, which meant obeying the king; *manumittere eum*,⁷ which means to emancipate, alluding to the custom and ceremony of slapping the slave to give him his freedom. And *intonuit coelum*,⁸ in Virgil, alluding to the omen of thunder in the west, which was taken as a good sign. And *nunquam leporem edisti*,⁹ in Martial, which has not only the charm of ambiguity in *leporem* but the allusion to the property the hare was said to possess. The proverb *Sailing the coast of Malia means forgetting what you have at home*, which alludes to the great danger of the promontory of Laconia.¹ The reply of the chaste matron to the insistent suitor, *the hinges will not be greased on my account, nor will the torches be lit*, meaning she did not wish to marry, alluding to the ceremony of greasing doors with fat and lighting nuptial torches at weddings;² as if we were to say today: no dowry will be paid on my account and the priest will give no blessings. There are so many comments of this kind in Virgil and Homer and all the poets and orators. And aside from this, what difficulties are not found in sacred passages, even in matters of grammar, such as using the plural for the singular, or moving from the second to the third person, as in the Song of Songs: *Let him kiss me with the kiss of his mouth, for thy breasts are better than wine*?³ Or placing adjectives in the genitive instead of the accusative, as in *I will take the chalice of salvation*?⁴ Or using the feminine for the masculine, and calling any sin adultery?

All of this demands more instruction than some think who, as simple grammarians or at most with a few terms of formal logic, attempt to interpret Scriptures and seize on *Mulieres in Ecclesiis taceant*, not knowing how it is to be understood. Or *Let the woman learn in silence*,⁵ this being a passage more in favor of women than

6. Luke 7:44–45 recalls Christ's complaint to Simon that he has received neither a kiss nor water to wash his feet [Editor].

7. That is, "emancipate him." Refers to the commonly held idea that slaves were freed with a slap. In Roman law, referred to the purple robes worn by emperors [Editor].

8. Misquotes *intonuit laevum, et de caelo lapsa per umbras* in Virgil, *Aeneid* II.693 ("it thundered on the left and [a star] fell from the skies"). Lawrance notes that it is likely that Sor Juana has culled these phrases from a Renaissance compendium of adages. Lawrance, n. 118 [Editor].

9. "You never ate hare" from Martial, *Epigrammata*, v.29: *edisti numquam, Gellia, tu leporem* (You, Gellia, have never eaten hare). It was believed that eating hare heightened a woman's beauty. In Latin, *leporem* was a pun on *hare* and *charm* [Editor].

1. Lawrance identifies this as "a well-known Greek proverb" referring to the promontory of Laconia in the Peloponnese and cited in Strabo's *Geography*, VIII.6.20. Lawrance, n. 119 [Editor].

2. Anointing doorways and thresholds and burning torches were Roman marriage rituals. It is unclear who the chaste matron is [Editor].

3. Song of Songs 1:1.

4. Psalm 116:13.

5. 1 Timothy 2:11. The full citation is: "Let the women learn in silence with all subjection" [revised by Editor].

against them, for it commands that they learn, and while they are learning, it is evident they must be silent. And it is also written: *Take heed and hearken, O Israel*,⁶ where all men and women are addressed, and all are ordered to be silent, because the person who hears and learns of necessity must also attend and be silent. If this is not so, I should like these interpreters and expounders of Saint Paul to explain to me how they understand the passage *Mulieres in Ecclesia taceant*. Because they must understand it either as physical, the pulpits and cathedras,⁷ or formal, the universality of the faithful, which is the Church. If they understand it in the first sense (which is, in my opinion, its true meaning, for we see that, in fact, women are not permitted to read publicly or preach in the Church), why reproach women who study privately? And if they understand it in the second and want the prohibition of the Apostle to be transcendent, so that not even in secret would women be permitted to write or study, why do we find that the Church has permitted Gertrude, Teresa, Birgitta, the Nun of Ágrede,⁸ and many other women to write? And if they tell me these women were saints, it is true, but that does not negate my argument; first, because the proposition of Saint Paul is absolute and embraces all women without excepting saints, for in his day there were also Martha and Mary, Marcella, Mary⁹ the mother of Jacob, Salome, and many others in the fervor of the early Church, and he does not exempt them; and now we find that the Church permits women who are saints and those who are not saints to write, for the Nun of Ágrede and Sor María de la Antigua are not canonized, and their writings circulate; neither were Saint Teresa¹ and the others when they wrote, which means that the prohibition of Saint Paul was directed only at the public pulpits, for if the Apostle had prohibited writing, the Church would not have permitted it. Now, I do not have the courage to teach—for that would be excessive presumption in me—and writing requires greater talent than mine, and very great deliberation. As Saint Cyprian says: *The things we write demand the most careful consideration*.² All that I have wished is to study in order to be ignorant about less: for,

6. Not found in the Bible but rather in Saint Jerome, *Letter to Eustochium* (Letter 108.27) [Editor].

7. Bishops' official thrones.

8. Sor María de Ágrede (1602–1665), Spanish mystic, nun, and author of *The Mystical City of God*, an autobiography of the Virgin Mary. Saint Birgitta (1303–1373), mystic and the founder of the Bridgettine nuns and monks [Editor].

9. The mother of James and Salome and a servant of Christ's who helped bury him in the Sepulchre (Mark 15:40–16:8). The sisters Martha and Mary housed Christ (Luke 10:38–42; John 11:1–6, 12:1–8). Sor Juana might be confusing Jerome's correspondent Marcella in this list [Editor].

1. Saint Teresa of Ávila (d. 1582) was not canonized until 1622. Sor María de la Antigua (1566–1617), Spanish mystic and author of *Desengaño de religiosas* (Disillusion of religious women, 1678) [Editor].

2. This phrase has not been located in Saint Cyprian's writings [Editor].

according to Saint Augustine, one learns some things in order to do them and others only to know them: *Discimus quaedam, ut sciamus; quaedam, ut faciamus.*³ Then where is my offense if I refrain even from what it is legitimate for women to do, which is to teach by writing, because I know I do not have the disposition to do so, following the advice of Quintilian: *Let each person learn not only from the precepts of others but from his own nature?*⁴

If my crime lies in the *Athenagoric Letter*, did that do more than simply refer to my opinion with all the reverence I owe to our Holy Mother Church? If she, with her most holy authority, does not forbid me to do so, why should others? Expressing an opinion contrary to that of Vieira was insolence in me, and expressing an opinion contrary to that of three Holy Fathers of the Church⁵ was not insolence in his paternity? Is not my understanding, such as it is, as free as his, for it comes from the same soil? Is his opinion one of the revealed principles of our Holy Faith, so that we must believe it blindly? Moreover, I did not fail in the deference owed to so great a man, which his defender lacked in addressing me, having forgotten the judgment of Titus Lucius: *Respect is companion to the arts*; nor did I criticize in any way the Society of Jesus; and I wrote only for the judgment of the one who suggested I do so; according to Pliny, *the state of the person who publishes is not the same as that of one who merely speaks.*⁶ For if I had thought the letter would be published, it would not have been as carelessly written as it was. If it is, as the censor says, heretical, why does he not denounce it?⁷ Then he would be avenged and I content, for I value more, as I should, the name of Catholic and obedient daughter of my Holy Mother Church than all the praise for being learned. If it is brutish—and they do well to say so—then let him laugh, even if it be with feigned laughter, for I do not tell him to praise me, and just as I was free to disagree with the opinion of Vieira, anyone else is free to disagree with mine.

3. Saint Augustine, Psalm 118, Sermon 17.3: *Cum itaque alia sint quae ideo discimus ut tantummodo sciamus, alia vero ut etiam faciamus* (Some things we learn so we may know them, and others so we may act upon them) [Editor].

4. The passage is a misquotation and misunderstanding of Quintilian, *Institutio Oratoria*, 2.11.1: *qui nihil egere huiusmodi praeceptis eloquentiam putent, sed natura sua et vulgari modo et scholarum exercitatione contenti rideant etiam diligentiam* (For they will urge that eloquence can dispense with rules of this kind and, in smug satisfaction with themselves and the ordinary methods and exercises of the schools) [revised by Editor].

5. In his Maundy Thursday Sermon, Vieira argues against Augustine, Thomas Aquinas, and John Chrysostom [Editor].

6. The source for this citation from Pliny the Elder has not been identified. There is no author named Titus Lucius: the phrase attributed to him is a misquotation of Quintilian's *Institutio Oratoria*, 9.4.8: *comitetur semper artem decor* (embellishment always accompanies art). "Society of Jesus": Vieira was a member of the Jesuit order, known for their corporate discipline and power in late-seventeenth-century Mexico. Sor Juana underscores that her critique is only of Vieira and does not reflect on the Jesuits as a whole [Editor].

7. Sor Juana employs the term "censor" metaphorically to refer to her critics, perhaps alluding to the charge of heresy to which she refers [revised by Editor].

But where is this taking me, señora? This does not apply here, and it is not for your ears, but since I am speaking of my accusers, I recalled the phrases of one, which appeared recently, and without being aware of it my pen slipped into an attempt to respond to him in particular, when my intent was to speak in general. And so, returning to our Arce, he says he learned of two nuns in this city: one in the Convent de Regina, who had memorized the breviary so well that she applied its verses, psalms, and the aphorisms and homilies of the saints with great quickness of mind and correctness in her conversation. The other, in the Convent de la Concepción, was so accustomed to reading the epistles of my father Saint Jerome, as well as the saint's words, that Arce says: *I thought I heard Jerome himself, speaking in Spanish*. And about her he says that he learned, after her death, that she had translated the epistles into Spanish; and it pains him that talents like these had not been used in greater studies with philosophical principles, and he does not say the name of either one, although he alludes to them as confirmation of his judgment, which is that not only is it legitimate but very useful and necessary for women to study sacred letters, nuns in particular, which is what you in your wisdom exhort me to do, and with which so many authorities concur.

If I turn to my ability, so often criticized, to make verses—which is so natural in me that I even have to force myself not to write this letter in verse, and I might say: *Everything I wished to say took the form of verse*⁸—seeing it condemned and incriminated so often by so many, I have searched very diligently for what may be the harm in it and have not found it; rather, I find verses in the mouths of the Sybils applauded, and sanctified in the pens of the prophets, especially King David, about whom the great expositor and my beloved father says, explaining the measure of his meters: *In the manner of Horace and Pindar*,⁹ *now it races in iambs, now the alcaic resounds, now it rises in sapphic, now it moves forward with broken feet*. Most of the sacred books are in meter, such as the Books of Moses, and Saint Isidore says, in his *Etymologiae*, that the Book of Job is in heroic verse.¹ Solomon wrote the *Song of Songs* in verse, as did Jeremiah the *Lamentations*.² For this reason, says Cassiodorus:³ *All*

8. From the Roman poet Ovid (43 B.C.E.–17 C.E.), *Tristia* (Lamentations) 4.10.26 [Editor].

9. Greek poet (ca. 522–ca. 443 B.C.E.). King David was the reputed author of many biblical Psalms. The quotation is from Saint Jerome, preface to *Chronicle* (written ca. 380 C.E.). Horace, or Quintus Horatius Flaccus (65–8 B.C.E.), Latin poet, and author of *Odes*; he admired Pindar [Editor].

1. Isidore, *Etymologiae*, 6.2.14. The canticle of Moses is found in Exodus 15:1–19 [Editor].

2. The biblical book *Lamentations* is attributed to Jeremiah (ca. 650–ca. 585 B.C.E.), a Hebrew prophet. The *Song of Songs* is traditionally attributed to Solomon [Editor].

3. Flavius Magnus Aurelius Cassiodorus (ca. 485–ca. 585 C.E.). Roman senator and later a monk who founded a monastery at the Vivarium outside Rome. The phrase has not been identified among his writings [Editor].

poetic locutions originate in Holy Scripture. Our Catholic Church not only does not scorn verses but uses them in its hymns and recites those of Saint Ambrose, Saint Thomas, Saint Isidore,⁴ and others. Saint Bonaventure⁵ was so fond of them that there is scarcely a page of his that does not contain verses. It is evident that Saint Paul studied them, for he cites and translates verses of Aratus: *For in him we live, and move, and have our being*,⁶ and cites another by Parmenides: *The Cretians are always liars, evil beasts, slothful bellies*.⁷ Saint Gregory Nazianzen⁸ argues questions of matrimony and virginity in elegant verses. Why should I grow weary? The Queen of Wisdom and Our Lady, with her sacred lips, intoned the Canticle of the Magnificat;⁹ and having presented her as an example, it would be an offense to present profane examples, although they may be very serious and learned men, for this is more than enough proof; and seeing that, although Hebrew elegance could not fit into Latin measure, for which reason the holy translator, more attentive to the importance of the meaning, omitted the verse, but even so, the psalms retain the name and divisions of verses; then where is the harm in them? Because the art is not to blame for its evil use but the one who professes evil and debases it, making it a snare of the devil; and this occurs in all the arts and sciences.

If the evil lies in a woman writing verses, it is clear that many have done so in a praiseworthy way; where is the evil in my being a woman? Of course I confess that I am base and despicable, but in my judgment no verse of mine has been called indecent. Moreover, I have never written anything of my own free will but only because others have entreated and ordered me to; I do not recall having written for my own pleasure except for a trifle they call *The Dream*.¹ The letter that you, my lady, so honored was written with more repugnance than anything else, because it dealt with sacred matters for which (as I have said) I have a reverent awe, and because it seemed to impugn, something for which I feel a natural aversion. And I believe that if I could have foreseen the fortunate destiny to

4. The *Te Deum* hymns were attributed to Saint Ambrose. The *Pange Lingua*, to Saint Thomas. The hymns by Isidore have not been identified [Editor].

5. A Franciscan friar and scholastic theologian (1221–1274) [Editor].

6. Acts 17:28. Aratus (ca. 310–240 B.C.E.): a Greek poet.

7. The citation is credited to the philosopher and poet Epimenides (7th or 6th century B.C.E.), not to the pre-Socratic philosopher Parmenides. Titus 1:12 [revised by Editor].

8. Saint Gregory of Nazianzus (329–389 C.E.) was a Greek Father known for his verse. Also cited by the Bishop Santa Cruz in his "Letter from Sor Filotea" on p. 87 [Editor].

9. A prayer from Mother Mary's speech at the Visitation (see p. 91, n. 5): "My soul magnifies the Lord," Luke 1:46–55 [Editor].

1. Sor Juana's mention of the poem now known as "First Dream" (p. 45) is the only indication that it was written before 1691, when she wrote this "Response." This statement also shows that the poem circulated in manuscript before being published in 1692 in her *Second Volume*. Finally, her statement that "they call" the poem "The Dream" has fueled speculation that the term "First" in the published title was an insertion by the editor [Editor].

which it was born—for, like another Moses, I abandoned it in the waters of the Nile of silence, where it was found and treated lovingly by a princess like you²—I believe, I repeat, that if I had thought this would happen, I would have drowned it first with the same hands from which it was born, for fear the awkward blunders of my ignorance would be seen in the light of your wisdom. In this the greatness of your kindness is revealed, for your will applauds precisely what your brilliant understanding must reject. But now that its fate has brought it to your door, so abandoned and orphaned that you even had to give it a name, I regret that along with my imperfections, it also bears the defects of haste, not only because of my continuing ill health and the countless duties my obedience imposes, and because I lack someone to help me write and feel the need for everything to be in my own hand, and because writing it went against my nature and all I wanted was to keep my promise to one I could not disobey, I did not have the time to refine it; as a consequence I failed to include entire discourses and many proofs that I had at hand but did not add in order to stop writing; and if I had known it would be printed, I would not have omitted them, if only in order to satisfy certain objections that have been raised, which I could dispatch, but I shall not be so discourteous as to place such indecent objects before the purity of your eyes, for it is enough that I offend them with my ignorance without adding the insolence of others. If they happen to fly to you (for they are so light in weight they may), then I shall do as you command; for if it does not contravene your precepts, I shall never take up the pen in my own defense, because it seems to me that one offense does not require another in response, when one recognizes error in the very place it lies hidden, for as my father Saint Jerome says, *Good discourse does not seek secrets*,³ and Saint Ambrose: *Concealment is in the nature of a guilty conscience*.⁴ Nor do I consider myself refuted, for a precept of the Law says: *An accusation does not endure if not tended by the person who made it*.⁵ What certainly is worth pondering is the effort it has required to make copies. A strange madness to put more effort into stripping away approval than acquiring it! I, señora, have not wanted to respond, although others have without my knowledge: it is enough that I have seen some papers,⁶ among them one that I send to you because it is learned and because reading it makes up in part for

2. The baby Moses was abandoned in a basket by the Nile river but was rescued by Pharaoh's daughter (Exodus 2:1–10), just as the *Athenagoric Letter* was rescued by the "princess," Sor Filotea [Editor].

3. Saint Jerome, *Letter to Gaudentius* (413 C.E.) (Letter 128.3) [revised by Editor].

4. Saint Ambrose, *On Abraham*, 1.2.4 [Editor].

5. This statement has not been found in either civil or canon law [Editor].

6. Sor Juana refers to contemporary writings that attacked and defended her *Athenagoric Letter* [Editor].

the time you have wasted on what I write. If you, señora, would like me to do the opposite of what I have put forward for your judgment and opinion, at the slightest sign of what you desire my intention will cede, as it ought to; it was, as I have said, to be silent, for although Saint John Chrysostom says: *Slanderers must be refuted, and those who question taught*, I see that Saint Gregory also says: *It is no less a victory to tolerate enemies than to overcome them*;⁷ and that patience conquers by tolerating and triumphs by suffering. And if among the Roman Gentiles it was the custom, at the height of the glory of its captains—when they entered in triumph over other nations, dressed in purple and crowned with laurel, their carriages pulled not by animals but by crowned, conquered kings, accompanied by spoils of the riches of the entire world, and the conquering army adorned with the insignias of its feats, hearing the applause of the people in their honorary titles of renown, such as Fathers of the Nation, Columns of Empire, Walls of Rome, Protectors of the Republic, and other glorious names—for a soldier, in this supreme moment of human glory and happiness, to say aloud to the conqueror, with his consent and by order of the Senate: “Remember that you are mortal; remember that you have these defects,” not forgetting the most shameful, which is what occurred in the triumph of Caesar, when the lowest soldiers called out in his hearing: “Beware, Romans, we bring you the bald adulterer.”⁸ This was done so that in the midst of countless honors the conqueror would not become vain, the ballast of these insults would counterbalance the sails of so much praise, and the ship of good judgment would not founder in the winds of acclaim. And I say that if Gentiles did this with only the light of natural law, we who are Catholics, with the precept of loving our enemies, what would we not do to tolerate them? For my part I can assure you that at times calumny has mortified me but never done me harm, because I take for a great fool the person who, having the opportunity to gain merit, endures the great effort and loses the merit, which is like those who do not wish to accept death and in the end die; their resistance does nothing to exempt them from death, but it does take away the merit of resignation and turns what might have been a good death into one that was bad. And so, señora, I believe these things do more good than harm, and consider the effect of praise on human weakness a greater risk,

7. According to Lawrance, the citation paraphrases the commentary on 1 Samuel 11:13 by Gregory the Great (ca. 540–604 C.E.), *Commentarii in librum 1 Regum* (commentaries on Book I of Kings) 5.1.13. The first statement is not found in the writings of the Greek Father John Chrysostom (347–407 C.E.) but rather in a text of the twelfth-century Zacharias Chrysopolitanus, *In unum ex quatuor* (In one of four), III. 127. Lawrance, n. 152 [Editor].

8. A similar line is recounted in Suetonius, *De vita Caesarum* (About the Life of the Caesars), “Divus Julius,” 51 [Editor].

for it tends to appropriate what is not ours, and we need to take great care to keep the words of the Apostle etched in our hearts: *And what hast thou that thou didst not receive? Now if thou didst receive it, why dost thou glory, as if thou hadst not received it?*⁹ so they can serve as a shield that resists the sharp points of praise, which are like lances that, when not attributed to God, to Whom they belong, take our life and turn us into thieves of the honor of God and usurpers of the talents He gave us and the gifts He lent us, for which we must give a strict accounting. And so, señora, I fear praise more than calumny, because calumny, with only a simple act of patience, is transformed into benefit, while praise requires many acts of reflection and humility and knowledge of oneself to keep it from doing harm. In my case, I know and recognize that knowing this is a special favor of God, allowing me to behave in both instances according to the judgment of Saint Augustine: *One should not believe the friend who praises or the enemy who censures.*¹ Although most of the time, given my nature, I squander what I have been given or combine it with so many defects and imperfections that I debase the good that came from Him. And so, in the little of mine that has been printed, not only my name but consent for the printing has been not of my own choosing but the will of another who does not fall under my control, as in the printing of the *Athenagoric Letter*; this means that only some *Exercises of the Incarnation* and *Offerings of the Sorrows* were printed for public devotion with my approval, but without my name;² I am sending copies of these to you, to give (if you agree) to our sisters the nuns of your holy community and others in the city. I am sending only one copy of the *Sorrows* because the others have been distributed and I could find no other. I wrote them years ago, solely for the devotions of my sisters, and afterward they became more widely known; their subjects are so much greater than my mediocrity and ignorance, and the only thing that helped me with them was that they dealt with our great Queen: it is notable that the iciest heart is set ablaze when one alludes to Most Holy Mary. I should like, illustrious señora, to send you works worthy of your virtue and wisdom, but as the poet said:

9. Apostle: Paul. 1 Corinthians 4:7 [revised by Editor].

1. Adapted from Saint Augustine, *Contra litteras Petiliani Donastistae* 3.10 (written ca. 400 C.E.): *nam si laudanti amico credendum non est, nec inimico detrahenti* (For, if you should not believe a praising friend, neither should you a detracting enemy) [Editor].

2. The original publication dates of the *Exercises of the Incarnation* and *Offerings of the Sorrows* are unknown. Both were published in the posthumous volume of her works, *Fame and Posthumous Works* (1700). These two works are important for Sor Juana's defense, as they fit the bishop's demands that she write on religious subjects. "Printed": the mystery play *The Divine Narcissus* had been published in Mexico in 1690, and a volume of her works, *Castalian Inundation*, had been published in Spain in 1689. Her *Second Volume* would be published the following year, in 1692. Sor Juana's *villancicos* and religious works were commissioned and printed separately, often without authorial attribution (see the chronology on p. 312) [Editor].

*Although strength may be lacking, the will must be praised.
I think the gods are satisfied with that.*³

If I write any other trifles, they will always seek out the sanctuary of your feet and the security of your correction, for I have no other jewel with which to pay you, and as Seneca says, whoever begins to offer benefits is obliged to continue them; in this way, your own generosity will repay you, for only in this way can I be freed in an honorable manner from my debt and avoid this warning from the same Seneca: *It is shameful to be surpassed in benefits.*⁴ For it is the magnanimity of the generous creditor to give the poor debtor what is needed to satisfy the debt. This is what God gave to the world incapable of repaying Him: He gave his own Son so that He would receive a recompense worthy of Him.⁵

If the style of this letter, illustrious señora, has not been what you deserve, I beg your pardon if in the homely familiarity or lack of respect in my treating you as a veiled nun, one of my sisters, I have forgotten the distance of your most eminent person, for if I had seen you without the veil, this would not have happened; but you, with your wisdom and kindness, will supply or amend the words, and if *vos* seems incongruous, I used it because it seemed that for the reverence I owe you, *Your Reverence*⁶ shows very little reverence; change it then to whatever seems honorable and what you deserve, for I have not dared to exceed the limits of your style or go past the boundary of your modesty.

Keep me in your grace and pray for divine grace for me and may the Lord grant you a large portion of it and keep you, which is my plea and my need. From this convent of our father Saint Jerome in Mexico City, on the first day of the month of March in the year 1691. I kiss your hand and am your most favored

Juana Inés de la Cruz

3. The poet is Ovid (*Epistulae ex Ponto* 3.4.79–80) [revised by Editor].

4. Seneca, *De Beneficiis* (On kindness) 5.2 [revised by Editor].

5. That is, he gave the world Jesus Christ [Editor].

6. Sor Juana should use "Your Reverence" in speaking to the bishop, as she does when writing to her confessor Reverend Father Antonio Núñez de Miranda in 1681. See "Letter by Mother Juana Inés" on p. 144. "Veiled nun": Sor Juana plays on the double meaning of veil, that is, a nun's veil or a disguise. "Vos": Sor Juana uses the familiar form of the second-person singular, reserved for informal and familiar relations [Editor].